

Fem Buddhism - K

TW: Fem Struggles

Modern society embraces a materialistic, capitalist worldview as the norm. Society as a whole centers self-interest, greed and avarice through the constant push to garner as many possessions and money as possible in spite of spiritual liberation.

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International Journal of Transpersonal Studies Volume 30 Iss. 1-2 (2011) Article 17 1-1-2011 Modern Materialism Through the Lens of Indo-Tibetan Buddhism Alan Pope University of West Georgia Follow this and additional works at: <https://digitalcommons.cis.edu/ijts-transpersonalstudies> Part of the Philosophy Commons, Psychology Commons, and the Religion Commons Recommended Citation Pope, A. (2011). Pope, A. (2011). Modern materialism through the lens of Indo-Tibetan Buddhism. *International Journal of Transpersonal Studies*, 30(1-2), 171–177.. *International Journal of Transpersonal Studies*, 30 (1). <http://dx.doi.org/10.24972/ijts.2011.30.1-2.171> This work is licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution-Noncommercial-No Derivative Works 4.0 License. This Special Topic Article is brought to you for free and open access by International Journal of Transpersonal Studies. It has been accepted for inclusion in International Journal of Transpersonal Studies by an authorized administrator. For more information, please contact the editors. Modern Materialism International Journal of Transpersonal Studies 171 Modern Materialism Through the Lens of Indo-Tibetan Buddhism Alan Pope University of West Georgia Carrollton, GA, USA The suffering that gives rise to and is perpetuated by contemporary culture's addiction to materialistic consumption is described surprisingly well by the ancient tradition of IndoTibetan Buddhism.

From this perspective, modern human beings exemplify hungry ghosts trapped in a state of incessant greed and insatiability, which at its core reflects a desperate attempt to maintain a sense of self that is out of accord with basic reality. The rich Tibetan Buddhist understanding of the unfolding process by which the hungry ghost negotiates its project, including its attempts to avoid greater suffering and to seek bliss, serves to elucidate our contemporary psychological dynamic. This analysis points to what is needed in order to extract ourselves from a consumerist mentality and find gentgy973, 1992). **As such, the hungry ghost symbolizes addictive greed and insatiability.** In this paper, I use this image and the philosophy of Indo-Tibetan Buddhism to shed light on the state of mind made presently manifest through contemporary consumerist culture.¹ **In so doing, I look beyond materialism as simply a historical-cultural phenomenon, situating it as the outward expression of a mental state endemic to the human condition,** one described with extraordinary detail by a spiritual tradition whose roots are more than 2500 years old. Modern Materialism The difficulties inherent in modern materialism have been well documented and empirically demonstrated (e.g., see Kasser, 2002; Kasser & Kanner, 2004). Csikszentmihalyi (2004) defined materialism as "the tendency to allocate excessive attention to goals that involve material objects: wanting to own them, consume them, or flaunt possession of them" (p. 92). In this instance, excessive means exceeding survival and encroaching on other important areas of a person's development and enjoyment. Kasser, Ryan, Couchman, and Sheldon (2004) described contemporary America's culture of consumption as having a materialistic value orientation (MVO). Copious research suggests that an MVO develops both as compensation for an insecure self-image and through social exposure to materialistic models and values. **These studies also demonstrate that this approach leads to lower subjective well-being and diminished concern for the welfare of others and the environment.** This latter aspect is not surprising given that **overconsumption—through its exploitation of natural resources and polluting of the environment—is the driving force behind the accelerating ecological crisis** (Starke & Mastny, 2010). The MVO operates

under the premise that by consuming more and more goods, we can be happy (throughout this article, all uses of “we” and “our” refer to human beings in the collective sense, while acknowledging that the author writes from his own specific location in Western culture). But does this strategy work? When I buy that new 46-inch flat screen TV, I may enjoy it for some time, taking pride in my possession, displaying it for others to see. I enjoy the crisp, clean images of my favorite programs. I might International Journal of Transpersonal Studies, 30(1-2), 2011, pp. 171-177 Keywords: hungry ghost, Indo-Tibetan Buddhism, materialistic value orientation, consumerism, neuromarketing, addiction, meditation 172 International Journal of Transpersonal Studies Pope spend countless hours watching it, freed momentarily from the other concerns and worries of my life. However, there remains a deep longing that in fact the TV does not fulfill. The TV becomes another fixture to fade into the background of my life. My unfulfilled desire turns its attention to new objects that might satisfy it. I return to the shopping mall, looking for my next conquest, which I make, and then the cycle repeats. In Buddhist parlance, I am caught in the cycle of samsara, a compulsive repetition of suffering that thrives on my failure to recognize the source of my suffering and of my happiness (Ray, 2000). The Six Realms In Buddhist theory, samsara is depicted by six realms, known as that of the gods, jealous gods, humans, animals, hungry ghosts, and hell beings (see Patrul Rinpoche, 1994, for vivid descriptions). These realms represent different states of mind through which we cycle in the course of a human lifetime. They are interdependently connected, and so we cannot understand one without the other. For instance, the insatiability and addictive tendencies of the hungry ghost are strategies for avoiding the rage and depression of the hell realms, where beings are depicted as suffering inconceivable torments—such as the repeated severing of limbs and gouging of eyeballs in settings of either extreme heat or cold, depending on the nature of the anger in whose grip one is held. This extreme aggression is, as Freud (1917/1957) suggested of depression, directed toward one’s own identifications of self, and the pain of the hell realms thereby conveys the intensity of suffering that can arise when self-hatred and rage become extreme. The desperate grasping of the hungry ghost helps it avoid falling into the terror of the hell realms and expresses its longing for the bliss of the god realm, where beings are endowed with beauty and wealth, and enjoy every conceivable pleasure (Trungpa, 1973). In contemporary Western culture, this desire to be a god is made visible in voyeuristic fascination with celebrities and their lives. However, we also exhibit the characteristics of the jealous gods—those who envy the gods and are paranoid about losing their own favorable position— whenever we wallow in a celebrity’s fall from grace. When we let go of such envy we can truly be human, meaning that while we live in desire, we are able to balance suffering with compassion. When our suffering becomes too difficult to bear, however, we sink into the ignorance of the animal realm, whereupon we may, for example, space out in front of our 46-inch flat screen TV. When that pleasure wears out, we are caught once again in the mindset of the hungry ghost, desperately afraid of the hell realms, and longing for the pleasures of the god realm. We return to the mall, opting for consumerism as our best chance at a stable state of being, albeit one that lives in fantasy and sacrifices compassion. Neuroscientific Materialism and the Hungry Ghost The underlying basis of the hungry ghost, and of the MVO, can be found in the philosophical doctrine of dualism, the position that mind and body are two completely different substances (Karr, 2007). This view is ultimately untenable, leading to two predominant solutions: (1) reducing everything to material reality, or materialism, and (2) reducing everything to mind, or idealism. Contemporary traditional neuroscience adopts the materialist view in its assumption that mind is an emergent property of underlying neurological structure and function. Given that this approach frames most conversations about addiction, it is worth considering briefly what light it might shed on the hungry ghost. In this view, the subjective mental experience of hunger arises from the complex interplay of numerous physical elements, including a variety of brain structures, blood sugar levels, and hormones (Le Magnen, 1985). Normally, this system maintains homeostasis, alternating between experiences of hunger and, upon eating, satiety. However, what makes food potentially addictive is that eating also provides a jolt of dopamine, the same pleasureinducing neurotransmitter that is implicated in drugs of abuse (Avena, Rada, & Hoebel, 2008; Stoehr, 2006). If our baseline dopamine levels are depressed, we might consume food beyond the point of physical satiety, or take drugs purely to get high, both of which provide short-term relief with negative long-term consequences. Hence, even at the neurobiological level, the essential root cause of the hungry ghost’s insatiable hunger is likewise the basis for substance addiction more generally. However, this same physical root cause can lead to all manner of craving. For example, even the sight or smell of food in the absence of actual consumption induces the release of dopamine levels (Zurawicki, 2010). Further, it has been shown that processing novel visual or cognitive information also elevates dopamine (in addition to activating opioid receptors in association areas of the cerebral cortex; Biederman & Vessel, 2006; BrombergMartin & Hikosaka, 2009). Thus, seeing food, smelling Modern Materialism International Journal of Transpersonal Studies 173 food, consuming drugs, viewing novel displays, thinking about interesting new things—all have the capacity to induce a chemical experience of pleasure and the craving that comes with it. A new discipline calling itself neuromarketing is exploiting these findings and applying them to the task of developing ways to maximize potential customers’ dopamine surges and other consumption-friendly biological processes (Zurawicki, 2010; Lindstrom, 2010). For example, if a product is displayed strategically, a dopamine rush will induce a purchase, even as the ensuing “crash” leaves us wondering what we were thinking (Lindstrom, 2010). Neurologically speaking, humans are wired for all manner of consumption, and advertisers—just as they have done in the past with behaviorism and psychoanalysis—are exploiting the latest trends in psychology in order to stimulate desire, increase profit, and populate the world with ever more hungry ghosts. Nevertheless, there is a growing body of evidence that this wiring can be changed. Neuroplasticity and Meditation Just as physics has advanced to the point that it has overthrown its earlier limiting assumptions, the work of Richard Davidson and other neuroscientists is challenging the presuppositions of traditional neuroscience. In particular, they have demonstrated that the adult brain can change in response to experience, a phenomenon

termed neuroplasticity (Lutz, Dunne, & Davidson, 2007). This view is largely based on studies with highly experienced meditators in the Tibetan Buddhist tradition. Using brain imaging equipment, Davidson and colleagues found that in meditation these individuals could easily slip into a pronounced pattern of asymmetrical firing in the prefrontal cortex (Begley, 2007). This pattern, in which the left cortex is extremely active relative to the right, signals the inner subjective experience of energized happiness, joy, and well-being. The extreme degree to which this pattern was demonstrated—far beyond what non-meditators exhibit—suggests the potential to rewire the brain through mental training. Whereas it used to be thought that the prefrontal cortex only pertains to the highest levels of abstract reasoning, and that the limbic system was the seat of emotions, it is now known that the prefrontal cortex is neurologically connected with and mediates the centers of emotional processing (Begley, 2007). As such, cutting edge neuroscience is suggesting that mental training can change our relationship to our emotions, and that we can come to naturally have greater control over our urges and cravings. Actually, this is precisely what the Buddhist tradition teaches (Tsering, 2005). It stands to reason that studies of lower animals—generally the basis of addiction studies—will uncover the neurology of unmediated craving; however, investigations of highly conscious human beings show that neurological determinism is an inaccurate model. Human cognitive capacities can modulate emotional ones, and as such we need not be the puppet of advertisers and profiteers. The hungry ghost can be transformed. Beyond Materialism The studies by Davidson and his colleagues open onto even larger implications. They challenge the very assumptions of standard neurobiology—namely, that the mind is an emergent property of matter. If training the mind can affect neurology, then one must perhaps take seriously the suggestion made by the Dalai Lama (2005) that thoughts may give rise to chemical events. In that event, the brain should be viewed not as the origin of mind, but rather as mind's executive officer. The philosophical doctrine of materialism itself is thrown into question, and in turn it is necessary to question the cost of continuing to adopt it. In the words of Buddhist writer Andy Karr (2007), "these materialistic views can prevent us from understanding the causal relationships that are more important to us: the determinants of happiness and sorrow, bondage and liberation" (p. 79). In holding to a materialistic view, we look to the outer world for happiness, rather than looking within.

Indo-Tibetan Buddhism regards idealism— besides materialism, the other proposed solution to the problem of dualism—as the superior position, recognizing that all experience is mental, meaning that it first registers in the mind (Karr, 2007). Although this view is developed in great detail in the Cittamatra, or Mind Only School of Mahayana Buddhism, it is ultimately recognized as only partially correct, for the One Mind is itself a concept that is superimposed on reality (Gyatso, 1994). The Madhyamaka, or MiddleWay, teachings of Mahayana Buddhism assert that everything is ultimately neither mind nor matter, because neither ultimately exists. Rather, they both arise together, interdependently. It is only when we appeal to concepts that we see either mind or matter as prior. When we realize the middle way position, placing primacy on neither the mind nor material reality, we see vividly that the ego, or sense of "I," is an illusion. It neither exists in a solid way (the doctrine of eternalism), nor does it not exist altogether (the doctrine of nihilism). In order to escape the endless cycling through the six realms, we must see through our habituated patterns and realize the true nature of the self. When we closely examine the body, we see that it is composed of a collection of parts, such as blood, skin, sensory organs, internal organs, nerves, and so forth. These parts are composed of ever-smaller particles, none of which has an intrinsic, separate existence. If we examine the mind, we find an overlapping stream of thoughts, feelings, impressions, and sensations, none of which exists independently. What we call a self is really a succession of experiences onto which we have imputed various concepts, the most central one being "I." That is, our sense of self is a fiction, a story we tell ourselves to give coherency to our experience. It exists not as a solid entity, but rather as a character in a social fabric of conceptual understanding and storytelling. Interdependent Existence The MVO is an integral part of the contemporary social fabric that gives definition and shape to our sense of self. In its part, the ego is not interested in consuming material goods in an authentic sense; rather, what the ego consumes is symbols. It is what things represent, what they tell about us—whether we are successful, affluent, desirable, or superior—that establishes their worth. In the meantime, we are actually covering over a tremendous sense of lack, hiding from the fact that we do not exist in the ways we conventionally think that we do. As David Loy (1996) has suggested, this lack is the deepest source of our anxiety, more fundamental even than the fear of death. In order to comfort ourselves in the face of this lack, we bow to what Chögyam Trungpa (1973) characterized as The Three Lords of Materialism: those of Form, Speech, and Mind. Of the first one, he explained: The Lord of Form refers to the neurotic pursuit of physical comfort, security, and pleasure. Our highly organized and technological society reflects our preoccupation with manipulating physical surroundings so as to shield ourselves from the irritations of the raw, rugged, unpredictable aspects of life...The Lord of Form does not signify the physically rich and secure life-situations we create per se. Rather it refers to the neurotic preoccupation that drives us to create them, to try to control nature. (pp. 5-6) The deep source of our consumerist mentality can be seen in this neurotic pursuit of comfort, security and pleasure, the compulsion to control the seeming chaos of life. This approach to life reflects a basic confusion about ourselves and our actions. When we recognize that mind and matter arise together, and that we do not exist in an intrinsic and separate way, we realize that no one phenomenon can appear except in interdependent relationship with all other phenomena. This realization invites a deeper understanding of the consequences of our consumerist actions. We recognize not only that habitual consumption is not in the service of our own happiness—it is as well deeply unethical, for its far-ranging impact places our collective survival in jeopardy. Genuine Happiness In the most basic sense, the MVO cannot promote true happiness because it is based on a principle of satisfaction rather than fulfillment. When we seek satisfaction, we seek the external conditions whereby we can feel temporarily sated. Inevitably, however, as conditions change, these states of satiation fade and new hunger arises. Even so, the ancient philosophical doctrine of hedonism regarded the pursuit of pleasure as the highest good (Kashdan, Biswas-Diener, & King, 2008). In its subtler versions, such as that expressed by Epicurus, a greater happiness necessitates that we use moderation in order that excessive indulgence not lead to excessive pain (De Lacy, 1967). Nevertheless, in this view happiness depends on the manipulation of external circumstances in the pursuit of more rather than less (pleasure). Given that pleasure can only be

defined in contrast to pain, happiness is necessarily relative and fleeting. Insofar as Freud's economic model considered the pursuit of pleasure to be the ultimate motivating force of psyche, we can understand how it is that a successful psychoanalytic treatment aims merely to bring ordinary unhappiness to its patients (Freud, 1895/1955). It is laudable that the hedonistic view values immediate experience, for otherwise we would live in our thoughts about the past or the future, separated from reality as it is. However, that which is revealed in our immediate experience varies depending on the state of our mind. For example, we can be immediately present Modern Materialism International Journal of Transpersonal Studies 175 to feelings of greed or hatred without recognizing that such feelings are transitory and ultimately empty of any substantial reality. Immediacy without genuine presence leaves us vulnerable to surfing a series of ever-pressing desires and aversions. Instead, we must train our minds to rest in a panoramic awareness that sees mental states such as greed and hatred as adventitious phenomena that cannot touch the deep sense of our true nature. From this perspective, genuine fulfillment or happiness, rather than being the accumulation of pleasures, is "a deep sense of flourishing that arises from an exceptionally healthy mind" (Ricard, 2003, p. 19). From a Buddhist perspective, such mental health is gained through disciplined mental training of no less effort than that used to maintain our physical bodies in peak condition. Through the practices of contemplation and meditation we can face our fears and discomforts in a disciplined way. When we confront them directly, their force is diminished, for it is what we do not see that unnerves us. A mind that is consequently calm and balanced can withstand any external circumstance. While such happiness can be regarded as an objective state relating to the condition of one's awareness, it has subjective correlates. When times are prosperous, the fulfilled mind experiences joy; when times are difficult, it responds with courage (DeWit, 2001, March). Rather than being passive to events in the world, we choose the ways we interpret and respond to them. Rather than being a temporary experience, genuine happiness is an optimal state of being (Ricard, 2003). This form of happiness resembles the Hellenic concept of eudaimonia, which for Aristotle was an objective condition associated with living a life of contemplation and virtue (Waterman, 2008). Drawing upon the work of contemporary philosopher David Norton, Waterman (2008) explained: "Eudaimonia was seen as a consequence of 'living in truth to one's daimon' or 'true self,' when an individual strives toward excellence in fulfilling his or her personal potentials" (pp. 235-236). At this level, we can see Buddhist happiness as a strong form of eudaimonia in which the true self to be realized is the no-self, the self that exists beyond all concepts. However, the Greek conception of eudaimonia, particularly in its contemporary interpretation, preserves the sense of the self as intrinsic and separate. Waterman goes on to observe that whereas daimon originally meant guiding spirit, contemporary theorists regard it as a constellation of interrelated psychological processes. Although this description resonates with the Buddhist notion of the ego as a continuum of psychophysical events, it does not accord with Buddhism's understanding of our deepest nature. That is, it does not explicitly account for realizing our transpersonal potentials, those that enable us to let go of even the subtlest traces of greed and protective selfcherishing. Regaining the Natural State According to the Madhyamaka Shentong teachings of Tibetan Buddhism, all humans have the same basic nature at the core of their Being (Maitraya, 2000). This so-called buddha-nature is naturally and spontaneously wise, loving, and compassionate. However, it is obscured to the extent that we cling to ego identifications that keep the natural qualities of ourselves and our experience cloaked by layers of conceptual artifice. When that conceptual artifice, erected and maintained with the support of consumerist culture, tells us to seek pleasure and avoid pain—and not only sanctions shopping, but regards it as a nationalistic duty—then we are kept in a state of alienation from ourselves and from one another. We live as hungry ghosts, unable to really touch the material world, unable to touch each other, and unable to be sated in any meaningful way. We are removed from the possibility of genuine fulfillment. Genuine fulfillment arises to the extent that we can put the needs of others before our own. Such altruism is not simply a "random act of kindness"; rather, in Tibetan Buddhist thought it is a pervasive modality of being that we must cultivate in order to recover our true nature. Given that we are interdependent rather than independent beings, to think only of ourselves is to live out of accord with reality and to create the conditions for suffering. The material sensibilities of the modern age inculcate this deluded perception in us, imprisoning us in a vicious circle of heightened pleasure and subsequent pain. The way to overcome this state of affairs is to confront the fear and grief from which we are hiding, whereupon shopping will lose its appeal in favor of human connection and caring. References Avena, N. M., Rada, P., & Hoebel, B. G. (2008). 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A materialistic worldview forces sexualized roles upon women through displaying objectified bodies as the ideal they should strive for. This means materialism is uniquely bad for women in a way it is not for men as they experience dissatisfaction for not being able to achieve the untenable. This is inherently sexist as women are made to aspire to an unachievable ideal to be seen as 'worthy'.

Teng et al. 15' [Fei Teng, a School of Psychology, Center for Studies of Psychological Application, Guangdong Key Laboratory of Mental Health and Cognitive Science, The Base of Psychological Services and Counseling for "Happiness" @ South China Normal University, Guangzhou, China, "Situational cuing of materialism triggers self-objectification among women (but not men): The moderating role of self-concept clarity," https://drive.google.com/drive/u/1/folders/1Z6mD6kGI145TRkgoIH-bbFSiKc5M_dZShttps://drive.google.com/drive/u/1/folders/1ilhFRbEJ3h55zTDkFgmCXDRq3h27IV68] ww ak

Situational cuing of materialism triggers self-objectification among women (but not men): The moderating role of self-concept clarity Fei Teng a,*, Kai-Tak Poon b, Hong Zhang c, Zhansheng Chen d, Ye Yang e, Xue Wang da School of Psychology, Center for Studies of Psychological Application, Guangdong Key Laboratory of Mental Health and Cognitive Science, The Base of Psychological Services and Counseling for "Happiness" in Guangzhou, South China Normal University, Guangzhou, China b Department of Psychology, The Hong Kong Institute of Education, Hong Kong c Department of Psychology, Nanjing University, Nanjing, China d Department of Psychology, The University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong e School of Humanities, Changshu Institute of Technology, Changshu, China article info abstract Article history: Received 14 October 2015 Received in revised form 17 March 2016 Accepted 20 March 2016 Available online xxxx The present research examined the influence of materialism on self-objectification among women. The results provided converging support to the prediction that experimentally priming materialistic belief would increase women's (but not men's) self-objectification tendency (Studies 1, 2 and 3). Moreover, Study 3 revealed that women's self-concept clarity moderated the effect of materialism on self-objectification tendency, such that only women with low self-concept clarity reported higher self-objectification tendencies following a materialism reminder. These findings contribute to the literature by highlighting the role played by societal ideology in women's development of self-objectification and also identifying a protective factor against such an effect. Implications for research on objectification, materialism as well as women's well-being were discussed. © 2016 Published by Elsevier Ltd. Keywords: Self-objectification Materialism Self-concept clarity Gender differences 1. Introduction A Fiat 500 Abarth car commercial portrayed a passionate story that a man encountered a seductive Italian woman, who turned into the new Fiat car at the end of the commercial; a group of

blonde and big-breasted female models promoted Old Milwaukee beer in the famous Swedish Bikini Team campaign; an Abercrombie & Fitch women's slogan t-shirt said blatantly on the chest position, "Who needs a brain when you have these?" Seemingly unrelated, these advertisements promote material products in a way that subtly conveys the notion that women are valued on the basis of their bodies in a consumer society, unanimously suggesting a potential connection between materialism and a sexualized view of women. Although such a connection is implicated in advertisements, media portrayals and daily occurrences, it has never been empirically tested. The present research thus had two aims. First, it aimed to investigate this connection by examining whether materialism would increase women's adoption of a sexualized view upon themselves; and second, it aimed to identify a potential protective factor for such a negative effect, namely, whether self-concept clarity can weaken the effect of materialism on women's self-objectification tendency. 1.1. **Self-objectification and its antecedents**

Sexual objectification refers to the process of separating a woman's body with her person and reducing the woman to the status of a "mere instrument" for satisfying others' (usually men's) needs and desires (Bartky, 1990). It occurs frequently on a daily basis through mass media portrayals (Calogero, Davis, & Thompson, 2005; Harper & Tiggemann, 2008) and interpersonal encounters (Chen, Teng, & Zhang, 2013; Tiggemann & Boundy, 2008; Teng, Chen, Poon, & Zhang, 2015). According to the objectification theory (Fredrickson & Roberts, 1997), frequent encounters with sexual objectification will coax women into internalizing a third-party self-perspective and coming to see them-selves through sexually objectifying lens. This process is termed as self-objectification by Fredrickson and Roberts (1997).

Women who objectify themselves attach great importance to their appearance (Fredrickson & Roberts, 1997) and often habitually monitor their outward appearance from an observational perspective (i.e., body surveillance; Lindberg, Hyde, & McKinley, 2006). Previous studies have accumulated evidence on the deleterious effect of self-objectification of women. For example, women's self-objectification is associated with impaired cognitive performance (Fredrickson, Roberts, Noll, Quinn, & Twenge, 1998; Quinn, Kallen, Personality and Individual Differences 97 (2016) 220–228 * Corresponding author at: Department of Psychology, Center for Studies of Psychological Application, Guangdong Key Laboratory of Mental Health and Cognitive Science, The Base of Psychological Services and Counseling for "Happiness" in Guangzhou, South China Normal University, China. E-mail address: tengfei.scnu@gmail.com (F. Teng). <http://dx.doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2016.03.066> 0191-8869/© 2016 Published by Elsevier Ltd. Contents lists available at ScienceDirect Personality and Individual Differences journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/paid Twenge, & Fredrickson, 2006), higher levels of eating disorder (Calogero et al., 2005; Jung & Forbes, 2007) and sexual dysfunction (Sanchez & Kiefer, 2007; Steer & Tiggemann, 2008), and decreased intrinsic motivation (Gapinski, Brownell, & LaFrance, 2003). **Generally, self-objectified women report lower levels of life satisfaction and well-being (Mercurio & Landry, 2008). Given the negative impacts of self-objectification on women's well being, it is important and necessary to identify factors that can predispose women to self-objectification. According to the objectification theory (Fredrickson & Roberts, 1997), various situational factors can trigger**

self-objectification in women. For example, women are more likely to sexually objectify themselves when putting on a revealing swimming suit while standing in front of a full-length mirror (Fredrickson et al., 1998), reading contemporary women's magazines (Tiggemann & McGill, 2004), overhearing weight or appearance commentaries (Calogero, Herbozo, & Thompson, 2009), and detecting or anticipating a male gaze (Calogero, 2004). These studies consistently demonstrated that situational cues that make physical appearance salient will lead to self-objectification. However, a more recent study conducted by Calogero and Jost (2011) found that incidental exposure to benevolent or complementary sexism can cause women to objectify themselves, suggesting that certain cultural ideology, in which physical appearance is not the main focus, can also trigger self-objectification. This research, therefore, highlights the need for situating self-objectification in a broader context of societal ideology. In the present research, we focused on a peculiar and socially prevalent ideology, namely, materialism, and we proposed that materialism can increase women's self-objectification tendency. 1.2. Materialism and self-objectification. Materialism is a value system, which is defined as 'a set of centrally held beliefs about the importance of possessions in one's life' (Richins & Dawson, 1992, p. 308). Such a value orientation encompasses the desire for a lifestyle associated with image, fame, and success, as well as on wealth and possessions. According to the consumer culture impact model (Dittmar, 2008), modern consumer society is featured by two interconnected ideals, which are "material good life" and "body perfect", both of which represent a culturally-prescribed "ideal self". Generally, these two sets of values are bounded together and perpetuated mainly by advertising. In fact, former content analyses of visual media (e.g., fashion magazines, television advertising, and programming) demonstrated the prevalence of images depicting products associated with young, tall, and extremely thin women who epitomize the current beauty ideal (Malkin, Wornian, & Chrisler, 1999; Fouts & Burggraf, 1999, 2000). Moreover, isolated body parts of women, such as a bare stomach, buttocks, cleavage, or a bare chest, are often depicted in commercial products (Kolbe & Albanese, 1996; Sommers-Flanagan, Sommers-Flanagan, & Davis, 1993), thereby communicating a sexualized view of women. According to Maio, Pakizeh, Cheung, and Rees (2009), when certain values are situationally activated, an ensemble of corresponding values are likely to be co-activated, while incompatible values are often inhibited (Maio et al., 2009). **To the extent that "material abundance" and "body perfect" are compatible and are associated closely with each other, activating materialism should**

make women conform to beauty ideals. Our prediction that materialism may trigger self-objectification in women is consistent with prior research findings showing that reminders of materialism led female participants to be more dissatisfied about their bodies after viewing idealized body figures (Ashikali & Dittmar, 2011). This effect was especially salient among those high in materialistic value (Ashikali & Dittmar, 2011). However, due to the correlational nature of their study, a causal relationship between materialism and women's self-objectification cannot be established. Therefore, in the present research, we directly tested the impact of situational materialism on women's self-objectification and proposed that materialism would make women self-objectify themselves.

1.3. The moderating role of self-concept clarity People internalize culturally prevalent values to a different degree. Some people are more strongly influenced by cultural values, whereas others are more resilient to this kind of influence. Of particular interest in the present research are factors that could protect women from being influenced by the socially prevalent ideology, and we proposed that self-concept clarity is one such factor. Self-concept clarity is the structural aspect of self-concept which represents the extent to which knowledge components or specific self-beliefs are organized (Campbell, 1990). Generally, high self-concept clarity reflects a state that the content of self-concept (perceived self-attribute) is clearly organized, confidently defined, internally consistent, and temporally stable (Campbell, 1990; Campbell & Lavelle, 1993). Self-concept clarity is critical to people's daily functioning and health as research has found that a relative lack of clarity in self-concept correlates with global indicators of compromised functioning such as neuroticism, anxiety, and depression (Bigler, Neimeyer, & Brown, 2001; Campbell, 1990; Campbell, Assanand, & Di Paula, 2003; Campbell et al., 1996) as well as aggressive reactions to failure (Stucke & Spore, 2002). More importantly, Campbell (1990) posited that individuals with different levels of self-concept clarity should respond differently towards external forces, such that people with low self-concept clarity "should be more dependent on, susceptible to, and influenced by external" forces (p. 539). Building upon Campbell's (1990) theory, people low in self-concept clarity should be more vulnerable to the influences of culturally-prescribed values. This proposition is sustained by a recent research conducted by Vartanian (2009), revealing a negative association between self-concept clarity and the internalization of cultural ideals of attractiveness among women. Furthermore, a more recent study demonstrated that self-concept clarity is negatively associated with both thin-ideal internalization and appearance-related social comparison tendencies, suggesting that self-concept clarity contributes to the vulnerability towards women's body image problems (Vartanian & Dey, 2013). Therefore, we predicted that self-concept clarity would moderate the effect of materialism on women's self-objectification inclination, such that materialism would trigger self-objectification among women low in self-concept clarity but not in women high in self-concept clarity.

2. Overview of the current study In the present research, we aimed to investigate the impact of materialism, as a situationally induced factor, on women's self-objectification. Following prior research (e.g., Calogero & Jost, 2011; Morris, Goldenberg, & Heflick, 2014; Harper & Tiggemann, 2008), self-objectification was assessed with the Self-objectification Scale by Noll and Fredrickson (1998) and the body-surveillance subscale of McKinley and Hyde's (1996) Objectified Body Consciousness Scale. The former scale reflects the importance people assign to appearance attributes (e.g., weight) as compared to competence attributes (e.g., health) in defining their physical self-concept, and the latter captures the extent to which people habitually monitor their outward appearance. We predicted that incidental exposure to materialism will increase women's self-objectification tendency (Studies 1 to 3). Moreover, we expected that self-concept clarity would moderate the relation between materialism and self-objectification tendency, such that the predicted effects would only emerge among women with low self-concept clarity, but not in women with high self-concept clarity (Study 3).

3. Study 1 In Study 1, we directly tested the causal relationship between materialism and self-objectification variables in a sample of Chinese women. China has witnessed a great growth in its economic status as well as its participation in the global market. Rapid increases in the consumption of luxury goods imply that materialistic values are gaining power in its F. Teng et al. / Personality and Individual Differences 97 (2016) 220–228 221 influences on Chinese people. According to a survey conducted by a global research firm (IPSOS) across 20 countries, 71% of Chinese said that they gauge their success by the things they own. This percentage was significantly higher than that of any other nation in the world (IPSOS, 2013). Moreover, Wei and Talpade (2009) found that, overall, Chinese mature consumers are more materialistic than their American counterparts; and this effect was replicated in young Chinese consumers as well (Podoshen, Li, & Zhang, 2011). The prosperity of consumerism in China is also associated with the strict beauty standards as well as the objectifying perspective on women. By analyzing data from the Miss Hong Kong Beauty Pageant from 1975 to 2000, Leung and colleagues demonstrated that thinness and big waist to hip ratio were highly looked up upon in Chinese culture (Leung, Lam, & Sze, 2001). This beauty standard has been propagandized by media and communicated by parents or peers to women (Chen & Jackson, 2012) which makes Chinese women become increasingly dissatisfied about their bodies and constantly engage in the beautification of their outer appearances (Chen & Jackson, 2012; Jackson & Chen., 2007). In fact, for the past 20 years, a beauty economy-based largely on the production and consumption of feminine beauty, youth, and appearance — has risen to become China's third largest growth industry behind real estate and tourism (Luo, 2013). Yang (2011) maintains that objectifying societal changes have resulted in Chinese women's bodies becoming sources of increased scrutiny and those deemed to be defective are targeted for modification. **Therefore, we predicted that materialism can increase**

self-objectification in Chinese women. Following prior research (Bauer, Wilkie, Kim, & Bodenhausen, 2012), we presented female participants with advertisements of luxury products (vs. ordinary products) to activate the materialism belief, and then measured their state self-objectification and level of body-surveillance. Moreover, past research showed that self-objectified women are more inclined to engage in appearance management (e.g., dieting, undertaking cosmetic surgery) in order to bring themselves in line with cultural body ideals (e.g., Fredrickson et al., 1998; Calogero, Pina, Park, & Rahemtulla, 2010). Therefore, in the present research, we also measured participants' appearance management intention as indicated by their purchasing tendency for appearance-related products (e.g., slimming clothes). We expected participants to report a greater tendency to objectify themselves after viewing the materialistic advertisements, and that their self-objectification tendency would mediate the effect of materialism on appearance management.

3.1. Methods

3.1.1. Participants Sixty-three

female undergraduate students from a university in China (mean age = 21.08, SD = 1.07) participated in exchange for a small amount of monetary reward. Participants were recruited using flyers posted on the campus. They were randomly assigned to either the materialism condition or the control condition.

3.1.2. Procedures

Participants made appointments with the experimenter through email and went to a psychological lab to participate in the experiment during their assigned timeslots. We had told the participants in the advertisements that they would complete several unrelated tests during the experiment, including general personality tests and consumer attitudes, before they agreed to participate in this study. Upon arrival to the laboratory, participants' informed consent was obtained, and they were asked to work on a media evaluation task where they were instructed to evaluate several advertisements. Specifically, participants were presented with 3 pieces of advertisements, each of which was shown on a computer screen for 2 min. Participants were instructed to evaluate each advertisement for their clarity and level of fun. To manipulate materialism orientation, participants in the materialism group watched advertisements about luxury products (i.e., a luxury car, a luxury watch, and a luxury house); whereas participants in the control group viewed advertisements for more frugal versions of products in the same categories (i.e., an economical car, a cheap watch, and a budget apartment). To avoid priming people with idealized body images, which was found to be able to induce a state of self-objectification in previous research (Harper & Tiggemann, 2008), we did not include any images of women nor men in the advertisements. Moreover, we removed trade-marks from all the advertisements to avoid arousing any pre-existing attitudes or feelings towards different brands. Afterwards, to check the effectiveness of the manipulation, participants answered two items about their material beliefs based on their current feelings on a 7-point scale (1 = strongly disagree; 7 = strongly agree). The two items were: "I want a lot of luxury in my life" and "Owning material things can make me happy" ($r = .46$, $p < .001$). Next, participants completed measures of self-objectification variables.

1 The measures included the body-surveillance subscale of the Objectified Body Consciousness Scale (McKinley & Hyde, 1996) and Self-objectification Scale (SOQ; Noll & Fredrickson, 1998). The body-surveillance subscale measures the extent to which people habitually monitor their outward appearance from an observational standpoint. Participants were instructed to rate eight items on a 7-point scale (1 = strongly disagree; 7 = strongly agree). A sample item is "During the day, I think about how I look many times". Mean scores were calculated to provide an index of body-surveillance, with higher scores indicating more body-surveillance. This scale has been widely used in prior research and has demonstrated satisfactory reliability and validity in Chinese samples (Jackson & Chen, 2015; $\alpha = .89$ in the present sample). SOQ measures the degree to which people value their physical appearance as compared to their physical competence. Specifically, participants were asked to rank 10 body attributes in the order of their importance in defining their physical self-concept. Five of the attributes were appearance-related (i.e., weight, sexuality, body measurements, appearances, and muscle strength), whereas the other five were competence-related (i.e., health, strength, energy level, physical coordination, and physical fitness). The difference scores were calculated by subtracting the sum of competence scores from the sum of appearances scores, and a higher score on this scale indicates a greater focus on physical appearance in comparison with physical competence. The reliability of SOQ was determined by correlating the sum of the appearance ranks and the sum of the competence ranks (Hill & Fischer, 2008; Calogero & Jost, 2011) and the correlation coefficient was $-.99$ in the present sample, indicating satisfactory reliability. Furthermore, we modified the instructions of the two scales to capture participants' momentary states by asking participants to report their current feelings. Finally, participants were presented with three pictures of appearance-related products (i.e., slimming clothes, perfume, a hair curler) and three pictures of control products (i.e., a computer accessory, earphones, office stationery). The order of presentation was 1 All scales that were originally written in English were translated into Chinese by the first author and were then back-translated into English by a bilingual Psychology professor. Modifications were made until the authors agreed that the back translation matched the meaning of the original English version.2 A group of 58 students (4 males) helped to evaluate the products we used as dependent measures. Specifically, participants were asked to answer three questions regarding the products on 7-point scales, ranging from "not at all" to "very much". The three questions were: "How materialistic is the product?", "To what extent is this product related to people's appearance?" and "To what extent would you like to purchase the product?" A brief definition of the word "materialistic" (i.e., excessively concerned with physical comforts or the acquisition of wealth and material possessions) was provided. Participants were instructed to raise their hands when they had difficulties in understanding the items we used and no participants had questions. A repeated measures ANOVA analysis showed that the appearance related products were rated as more related to appearance ($M = 4.74$; $SD = 1.96$) than the ordinary products ($M = 2.41$; $SD = 1.52$), $F(1, 57) = 70.19$, $p < .001$. Moreover, participants were more willing to purchase the ordinary products ($M = 5.41$; $SD = 1.70$) than the appearance products ($M = 3.04$; $SD = 1.51$), $F(1, 57) = 85.78$, $p < .001$. However, these two kinds of products did not differ in the extent to which they are materialistic, $F(1, 57) = 3.02$, $p = .10$.2.2.2 F. Teng et al. / Personality and Individual Differences 97 (2016) 220–228 randomized. They were instructed to answer two questions including: "To what extent this product is desirable" and "To what extent would you like to purchase the product" on 7-point scales (1 = not at all, 7 = extremely). Mean scores were calculated separately for appearance products ($\alpha = .61$) and control products ($\alpha = .59$). At the end of the study, we probed participants' suspicions of the nature of the study, and none of them indicated suspicions about the real purpose of the study. After completing all the above tasks, participants were asked to provide their demographic information and were then debriefed before leaving. 3.2. Results and discussion All dependent variables were analyzed using a one-way ANOVA, with materialism as the between-subject variable. 3.2.1. Manipulation check Participants were more materialistic in the materialism condition ($M = 5.09$, $SD = 1.21$) than in the control condition ($M = 3.96$, $SD = 1.45$), $F(1, 61) = 10.19$, $p < .01$, $\eta^2 p = .14$. Therefore, our manipulation was successful. 3.2.2. Body-surveillance There was a main effect of materialism, $F(1, 61) = 10.54$, $p < .01$, $\eta^2 p = .15$, such that female participants reported greater body-surveillance in the materialism condition ($M = 4.84$, $SD = .77$) than in the control condition ($M = 4.13$, $SD = .89$). 3.2.3. State self-objectification The results showed that materialism exerted a significant main effect on state self-objectification, $F(1, 61) = 5.62$, $p = .02$, $\eta^2 p = .08$. Specifically, women who viewed advertisements of luxury products reported higher scores ($M = -8.33$, $SD = 8.88$) than those who viewed ordinary products in the Self-objectification Scale ($M = -13.33$, $SD = 7.64$). 3.2.4. Appearance management A repeated measures ANOVA with materialism priming as a between-subject variable and product type as a

within-subject variable revealed a significant interaction between priming and product type, $F(1,61) = 4.13$, $p = .05$, $\eta^2 = .06$, however, neither the main effect of priming nor product type were statistically significant, $F_s \leq 1.68$, $p_s \geq .20$. To clarify the nature of the expected interaction effect, we conducted a series of planned a priori comparisons. Specifically, simple effect analyses showed that there was a main effect of materialism on purchasing tendencies for appearance-related products, $F(1,61) = 4.55$, $p = .04$, $\eta^2 = .07$, such that female participants in the materialism condition reported greater willingness to purchase the appearance-related products ($M = 4.14$, $SD = 1.47$) than those in the control condition ($M = 3.19$, $SD = 1.85$). However, the effect was not observed on ordinary products between materialism primed participants ($M = 3.45$, $SD = 1.31$) and those assigned to the control condition ($M = 3.55$, $SD = 1.67$), $F(1,61) = .02$, $p = .88$.

3.2.5. Mediation analysis Using procedures recommended by Preacher and Hayes (2004), we treated the independent variable as the predictor, body-surveillance and state self-objectification as mediators, and appearance management as the criterion variable. This analysis revealed a significant indirect effect for body-surveillance (with 5000 iterations, bias corrected, and accelerated 95% confidence interval = .03 to .54). Inclusion of this mediator reduced the uncorrected experimental effect ($b = .26$, $p = .04$) to non-significance ($b = .14$, $p = .29$) (see Fig. 1), suggesting that participant's body-surveillance accounted for the effect of materialism on appearance management. However, the indirect effect of state self-objectification was not statistically significant (with 5000 iterations, bias corrected, and accelerated 95% confidence interval = -.27 to .05). Study 1 provided primary evidence that materialism cues are environmental triggers for self-objectification in women. Specifically, we found that women had an increased tendency to objectify themselves following exposure to materialism reminders, as indicated by an increased degree of body-surveillance and heightened importance assigned to appearance. Moreover, the increased body-surveillance mediated the effect of materialism on women's appearance management intentions. State self-objectification did not serve as a mediator in the relation between materialism and appearance management. This effect is in line with past research. In fact, although both body-surveillance and self-objectification demonstrated acceptable reliability and validity in previous studies, body-surveillance was shown to be more reliable in predicting criterion variables in the present study. Specifically, when self-objectification and body-surveillance were considered together, body-surveillance typically emerged as a variable uniquely related to the criterion variables while self-objectification did not (e.g., Greenleaf & McGreer, 2006; Szymanski & Henning, 2007; Calogero & Jost, 2011).

4. Study 2 In study 2, we aimed to replicate the findings of Study 1 in a U.S. sample. Moreover, we adopted another paradigm to manipulate the concept of materialism in order to increase the validity of the findings in Study 1. Following prior research (Bauer et al., 2012), we presented participants with pictures of luxury products to activate the materialism belief, and then measured self-objectification related variables. Furthermore, we also examined whether the effect of materialism on women's self-objectification can be extended to men. Previous studies showed that men will objectify themselves in certain circumstances. For example, when putting on a speedo swimsuit and standing in front of a mirror, men reported increased feelings of self-objectification (Martins, Tiggemann, & Kirkbride, 2007). However, in daily occurrences, self-objectification occurs more frequently in women than in men (Fredrickson & Roberts, 1997), and situational or interpersonal cues that can trigger self-objectification state in women usually have no such effects on men. For example, in their study, Saguy and colleagues found that female participants felt uncomfortable and refrained from exerting their presence in interpersonal interactions when talking to a person of the opposite sex when their bodies could be seen through a web-camera (Saguy, Quinn, Dovidio, & Pratto, 2010). However, this effect did not emerge for male participants (Saguy et al., 2010). Therefore, we expected that participants would report greater tendencies to objectify themselves after viewing materialism reminders, and this effect would only be observed in women.

Fig. 1. Body-surveillance mediates the effect of materialism on appearance management (Study 1) *** $p \leq .001$; * $p \leq .05$. F. Teng et al. / Personality and Individual Differences 97 (2016) 220–228 223

4.1. Methods

4.1.1. Participants One hundred and eighty-one participants (90 males and 91 females) from America participated in our study on Amazon Mechanical Turk (Buhrmester, Kwang, & Gosling, 2011) in exchange for a small amount of monetary reward. Participants were recruited using advertisements posted on Amazon Mechanical Turk. We had told the participants in the advertisements that they would complete several unrelated tests during the experiment, including general personality tests and a media evaluation task, before they agreed to participate in this study. The mean age of the participants was 37.22 years old ($SD = 12.88$) and the ethnic composition of the sample was: 81.2% were Caucasian, 6.1% were Asian, 5.5% were African, 3.9% were Hispanic, and 3.3% did not identify their ethnicity.

4.1.2. Procedures and materials After signing a consent form, participants were led to believe that they would complete several unrelated tasks to minimize their knowledge of our research hypotheses. First, participants were instructed to work on a picture evaluation task. Specifically, they were asked to evaluate 20 pictures, the presentation order of which was randomized. Participants were instructed to evaluate each picture in terms of their clarity and structure. To manipulate materialism, participants in the materialism condition viewed pictures depicting luxury products (e.g., a luxury car, luxury furniture); whereas participants in the control group viewed pictures of ordinary products (e.g., paper, an ordinary chair). To control possible confounding effects, none of the pictures included any images of women and men. Next, participants completed the same manipulation check questions used in Studies 1 and 2. Specifically, they rated the extent to which they agreed to each of the two statements "I want a lot of luxury in my life" and "Owning material things can make me happy" (1 = strongly disagree; 7 = strongly agree; $r = .40$, $p \leq .001$). Finally, participants completed the body-surveillance subscale ($\alpha = .80$) as well as the SOQ ($r = -.97$, $p \leq .001$) used in Study 1. To fit the research purpose of this study, participants were asked to complete the two scales based on their current feelings. After completing all the above tasks, participants were instructed to provide their demographic information, and were then directed to a funneled debriefing page.

4.2. Results and discussion All dependent variables were analyzed using a two-way ANOVA, with materialism and gender as the between-subject variables.

4.2.1. Manipulation check Participants were more materialistic in the materialism priming condition ($M = 4.22$, $SD = 1.66$) than in the control condition ($M = 3.66$, $SD = 1.54$), $F(1,177) = 4.51$, $p = .05$, $\eta^2 = .03$. The interaction

between materialism and gender was not significant, $F(1,177) = 1.72, p = .19$. Therefore, our manipulation was effective.

4.2.2. Body-surveillance

There was a main effect of gender, $F(1,177) = 10.78, p = .001, \eta^2 = .06$, such that female participants scored higher on the body-surveillance scale ($M = 4.07, SD = 1.23$) than male participants ($M = 3.59, SD = 1.28$). The main effect of materialism was not significant, $F(1,177) = .13, p = .72$. More importantly, the interaction of condition and gender was significant, $F(1,177) = 7.62, p = .01, \eta^2 = .04$. To clarify the nature of the expected interaction effect, we conducted a series of planned a priori comparisons. Specifically, simple effects tests demonstrated that female participants scored higher on body-surveillance in the materialism condition ($M = 4.42, SD = 1.32$) than in the control condition ($M = 3.82, SD = 1.11$), $F(1,177) = 5.30, p = .02, \eta^2 = .06$; however, male participants did not differ on body-surveillance between the materialism condition ($M = 3.25, SD = 1.08$) and the control condition ($M = 3.72, SD = 1.33$), $F(1,177) = 2.66, p = .10$. Further tests showed that female participants reported more surveillance ($M = 4.42, SD = 1.32$) than male participants after a materialism reminder, $F(1,177) = 13.88, p = .001, \eta^2 = .07$; and this effect was not observed in the control condition, $F(1,177) = .19, p = .66, \eta^2 = .02$.

4.2.3. State self-objectification

The main effect of gender was marginally significant, $F(1,177) = 3.71, p = .05, \eta^2 = .02$, such that female participants reported greater state self-objectification ($M = 4.38, SD = 14.22$) than male participants ($M = 1.84, SD = 14.34$). The main effect of materialism was not significant, $F(1,177) = 2.32, p = .14$. More importantly, the interaction of condition and gender was significant, $F(1,177) = 4.01, p = .04, \eta^2 = .02$. To clarify the nature of the expected interaction effect, we conducted a series of planned a priori comparisons. Specifically, simple effect analyses demonstrated that female participants scored higher on self-objectification in the materialism condition ($M = 9.92, SD = 12.53$) than in the control condition ($M = 2.13, SD = 13.97$), $F(1,177) = 5.65, p = .02, \eta^2 = .03$; however, male participants did not differ on self-objectification between the materialism condition ($M = 1.16, SD = 12.13$) and the control condition ($M = 2.30, SD = 15.77$), $F(1,177) = .14, p = .71$. Further tests showed that female participants reported more self-objectification than male participants after a materialism reminder, $F(1,177) = 5.87, p = .02, \eta^2 = .03$; and this effect was not observed in the control condition, $F(1,177) = .004, p = .94$.

Our second study provided further evidence about the association between materialism orientation and self-objectification inclination in a U.S. sample. Moreover, we found that situational reminders of materialism can trigger self-objectification tendencies in women but not in men. This effect is consistent with past research showing that environmental and interpersonal triggers of women's self-objectification usually do not lead to the same effects in men.

5. Study 3

In Study 3, we aimed to replicate the patterns we found in Studies 1 and 2. More importantly, we investigated whether self-concept clarity could buffer the effect of materialism cues on women's self-objectification related variables. We predicted that materialism would increase women's tendency to objectify themselves among those low in self-concept clarity, but not among those with high self-concept clarity.

5.1. Methods

5.1.1. Participants

Ninety-eight female undergraduate students from a university in China (mean age = 22.11, $SD = 1.23$) participated in exchange for a small amount of monetary reward. Participants were recruited using flyers posted on campus. They were told that they would complete 3 None of the materialistic products and control products were related to physical appearance (e.g., jewelry) in order to rule out the possibility that appearance cues embedded within the pictures increase women's self-objectification. A pilot study was conducted on 60 undergraduates from a university in China to check the effectiveness of our manipulation. Specifically, participants were asked to evaluate the products on 9-point scales, ranging from "not materialistic" to "very materialistic" and from "very unpleasant" to "very pleasant". A brief definition of the word "materialistic" (i.e., excessively concerned with physical comforts or the acquisition of wealth and material possessions) was provided. Participants were instructed to raise their hands when they had difficulties in understanding the items we used and no participants had questions. The results showed that the materialistic products were rated as more materialistic ($M = 8.50, SD = 1.05$) and more pleasant ($M = 4.09, SD = 1.05$) than the control products (materialistic: $M = 3.08, SD = 1.35$; pleasant: $M = 2.96, SD = 1.43$), $F(1,96) = 6.07, p = .02, \eta^2 = .06$.

5.1.2. Procedures

Participants made appointments with the experimenter through email and went to a psychological lab in their assigned timeslots. After written consents were provided, participants were told to perform several alleged unrelated tasks. First, participants completed the 12-item Self-concept Clarity Scale (Campbell et al., 1996). On 7-point scales (1 = totally disagree; 7 = totally agree), participants indicated the extent to which they agreed on 12 statements. A sample item is "My beliefs about myself seem to change very frequently." This scale was translated into Chinese by the first author and then it was back-translated into English by a bilingual Psychology professor. Modifications were made until the authors agreed that the back translation matched the meaning of the original English version. Mean scores were calculated to index the clarity of self-concept, with higher scores indicating higher levels of clarity ($\alpha = .81$). Afterwards, similar to Study 2, participants were instructed to work on a media image evaluation task. Specifically, 20 pictures were presented on a computer screen, with each shown for 2 s. Participants were asked to evaluate each picture in terms of its clarity and structure. To manipulate materialism orientation, all the pictures presented to participants in the materialism condition were about luxury products. Participants in the control group viewed pictures about natural scenes. The pictures were the same as those used in Study 2. Next, participants completed the same manipulation check questions as used in Studies 1 and 2 ($r = .48, p = .001$). Finally, participants completed the body surveillance subscale ($\alpha = .81$) and the SOQ ($r = -.99$) used in Studies 1 and 2. Participants were then asked to provide their demographic information, and were then debriefed before leaving.

5.2. Results and discussion

5.2.1. Manipulation check

Female participants were more materialistic in the materialism priming condition ($M = 4.78, SD = 1.07$) than in the control condition ($M = 3.34, SD = 1.26$), $F(1,96) = 12.44, p = .001, \eta^2 = .12$. Therefore, our manipulation was effective.

5.2.2. Body surveillance

We regressed participants' body-surveillance onto the materialism condition (control = -1, materialism = 1), perceived self-concept clarity (mean-centered), and the two-way interaction. The results revealed a significant main effect of materialism, $b = .20, t(94) = 2.12, p = .04$; and a main effect of self-concept clarity, $b = -.24, t(94) = -2.57, p = .01$. More importantly, the two-way interaction between materialism and self-concept clarity was significant, $b = -.22, t(94) = -2.32, p = .02$ ($R^2 = .17$; see Fig. 2). To clarify the nature of the expected interaction effect, we conducted a series of planned a priori comparisons. Specifically, follow-up simple slope analyses were conducted to determine group differences. Among participants low in self-concept clarity (1 SD

below the mean), participants in the materialism condition exhibited greater body-surveillance than participants in the control condition did, $b = .42$, $t(94) = 3.08$, $p < .01$. However, participants high in self-concept clarity (1 SD above the mean) did not differ between the materialism condition and the control condition on body-surveillance, $b = -.02$, $t(94) = -.14$, $p = .89$. Furthermore, among participants in the materialism condition, self-concept clarity was negatively associated with body-surveillance, $b = -.49$, $t(45) = -3.78$, $p < .001$. This association was not observed among participants in the control condition, $b = -.02$, $t(49) = -.16$, $p = .87$.

5.2.3. State self-objectification. Another multiple regression analysis was conducted to examine whether self-concept clarity interacted with materialism in predicting state self-objectification. The analysis revealed a significant main effect of materialism, $b = .22$, $t(94) = 2.20$, $p = .03$. However, the main effect of self-concept clarity, $b = .01$, $t(94) = -.10$, $p = .92$ and the interaction between materialism and self-concept clarity were both not significant, $b = -.02$, $t(94) = -.17$, $p = .87$ ($R^2 = .17$). Study 3 provided further evidence that materialism is a powerful environmental stimulus that will increase women's tendency to objectify themselves. Moreover, we found that self-concept clarity moderated this relation between materialism and women's body-surveillance, such that only women low in self-concept clarity exhibited heightened body-surveillance after a materialism reminder. These findings suggest that self-concept clarity could protect women against the negative influences of environmental pressures. However, we did not find any moderation effect of self-concept clarity on the relation between materialism and state self-objectification. This might be because the SOQ and the body-surveillance scale captured different aspects of self-objectification. Self-concept clarity can moderate the effect of materialism on women's behavioral intentions (i.e., actively monitor their body from an observational perspective) but not on women's perception of self-attributes (i.e., the assigned importance to appearance relative to fitness) as a whole. This effect also suggests the possibility that women's sexualized views of themselves are harder to modulate than that of their behavioral intentions.

6. General discussion In modern consumer society, popular media is overwhelmed by advertisements in which women are portrayed in a sexualized way, implicitly suggesting a connection between material possessions and a perfect body figure. We proposed that materialism is an environmental trigger of self-objectification for women, insofar as material abundance and a perfect body are socially valued ideals that connected to each other closely (Dittmar, 2008). Experimental evidence converged to support our proposition. Specifically, we situationally induced materialism belief by letting participants watch advertisements of luxury products or by presenting participants with pictures depicting luxury products in the three studies, and we found that situationally-induced materialism increased women's endorsement of a sexually-objectified perspective on themselves. This program of research provides the first experimental evidence that mere reminders of materialism will make women more inclined to objectify themselves. Prior research demonstrated that women exhibit increased tendency for self-objectification in situations where their body is made salient (e.g., Fredrickson et al., 1998; Tiggemann & Fig. 2. Self-concept clarity interacted with materialism to predict women's body surveillance (Study 3). F. Teng et al. / *Personality and Individual Differences* 97 (2016) 220–228 225 McGill, 2004; Calogero et al., 2009). The present research contributes to the objectification theory by showing that certain situational cues that do not contain any explicit information about the physical body could give rise to self-objectification. Our findings that materialism triggers self-objectification tendencies in women are in congruence with past research findings showing that materialism increases women's dissatisfaction about their body (Ashikali & Dittmar, 2011). We take this line of research a step further by drawing a link between materialism and self-objectification directly, thereby suggesting the possibility that women's increased dissatisfaction about their bodies might be due to an increased degree of self-objectification. Materialism exerts deleterious effects on people (for a review, see Kasser, 2002). Generally, materialistic people report lower self-esteem (Ryan et al., 1999), more negative affect (Christopher & Schlenker, 2004), and lower levels of well-being (e.g. Kasser & Ahuvia, 2002; Kasser & Ryan, 1993). However, women seem to be more vulnerable to the influences of materialism than men. A meta-analytical study found that, the link between materialism and lower well-being is stronger when women make up a greater proportion of the respondents (Dittmar, Bond, Hurst, & Kasser, 2014). Our research findings, therefore, could shed light on this line of research by pointing out the possibility that materialism inflicts its detrimental impacts especially on women

and through, at least partially, increasing women's self-objectification. The mechanism underlying materialism and self-objectification is contingent self-valuation. For materialists, their self-worth rests on material possessions and money they own; for self-objectifiers, their worth lies on the attractiveness and sexuality of their appearances. In a modern consumerist society, these two sets of values are interconnected and perpetuated together by advertisements emphasizing women's bodies. Having established the impact of materialism on women's self-objectification, the obvious next step would be to investigate the impact of self-objectification on people's attitudes towards material possession and acquisition. Will self-objectified women exhibit stronger desires for materials and money? Will self-objectified women pursue extrinsic financial goals at the expense of intrinsic psychological needs? Answers to these questions could help to better understand the influences of sexual objectification on women. In Study 1 we found that women increase appearance-management endeavors through purchasing appearance-related products as a response to a materialism reminder. Our research, therefore, provides insights for understanding women's consumption behaviors. For example, research showed that people engage in compulsive consumption, which refers to the tendency of excessively buying things at the expense of psychological health and financial security (Dittmar, 2004b). This trend is especially salient among women (see reviews by Black, 2004; Faber, 2004). Researchers believed that compulsive buying could be conceived of as a type of compensatory consumption whereby people deal with their identity problems in a materialistic society (Dittmar, 2004b; Elliott, 1994). It is thus plausible that the prevailing materialism values in a consumerist society increase women's concerns on their appearance, coaxing them into buying products which would bring them in line with the culturally-prescribed identity - a woman possessing a perfect body. Therefore, our research helps to understand the deleterious impact of materialism on women, and open up possibilities for future intervention programs targeting women's overall well-being and health. In Study 3, we found that individual differences in self-concept clarity affected how women responded to materialism, such that body-surveillance efforts were greater among low self-concept clarity women but weaker among high self-concept clarity women following exposure to materialism.

According to Campbell (1990), self-concept clarity influences the extent to which people internalize cultural values, with low self-concept clarity individuals more strongly subjected to environmental pressures. That is, low self-concept clarity individuals may seek external information to define themselves or form their identities due to a lack of a clear sense of who they really are. Therefore, women with low self-concept clarity would be more likely to internalize the culturally prescriptive ideals or make themselves become in line with the cultural ideal. In contrast, high self-concept clarity women did not show this effect, suggesting that self-concept clarity could somehow protect women against the negative consequences of materialism, which may otherwise be hard to resist. Given that a large part of the negative impacts of sexual objectification on women arises from women's internalization of an observational perspective on the self and view one's self through an objectified lens (for a review, see Moradi & Huang, 2008), our research provide possibilities for intervention programs. Specifically, if self-concept clarity could protect women from conforming to culturally prevalent ideologies, it is possible that self-concept clarity could play a role in helping women deal with other negative outcomes of sexual objectification. Thus, self-concept clarity appears to be a critical variable to consider in future investigations of sexual objectification. It should be noted that although state self-objectification and body-surveillance are both regarded as indexes of the tendency for women to objectify themselves, they exert their influences differently and respond differently to the potential protecting factor. For example, body-surveillance, but not state self-objectification, can serve as a mediator in the relation between materialism and appearance management. Moreover, self-concept clarity can moderate the relation between materialism and body-surveillance (but not self-objectification). We think the different pattern of results might be because the SOQ and the body-surveillance scale capture different aspects of self-objectification. Specifically, body-surveillance is more of a reflection of women's behavioral intentions (i.e., actively monitor their body from an observational perspective), whereas state self-objectification is about women's perception of self-attributes (i.e., the assigned importance to appearance relative to fitness). It is, thus, worthy of further investigation to further differentiate these two constructs as well as the way they exert their peculiar influences on women. In sum, by building up the connection between materialism and women's self-objectification, the present research provides a crucial foundation for understanding the deleterious effect of materialism on women's general well-being and mental health. We hope it marks a new avenue for future research into the details of the link between materialism and self-objectification as well as the potential reciprocal nature of their relationship. The moderating effect of self-concept clarity upon their relation also sheds lights on future intervention programs targeting women struggling in the contemporary consumer society. Moreover, our research contributes to literature on self-objectification by providing cross-cultural evidence on the prevalence of this phenomenon. Previous research on self-objectification has emphasized western women of European heritage; however, the body image issue is not culture-bounded. Previous literature demonstrated cross-sectionally (Jackson & Chen., 2007; Xu et al., 2010), longitudinally (Jackson, 2011; Jackson & Chen, 2013) and experimentally (Gao et al., 2011) that body dissatisfaction as well as its health consequences, such as eating disorders and depression, is rising and has become one of the most important risks that harm modern Chinese women's physical and mental health. Moreover, recent research has provided some evidence showing that objectification influences people from the western and eastern cultures similarly. In particular, both Chinese and American women tend to avoid interacting with men following sexual objectification (Saguy et al., 2010; Teng et al., 2015).

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In the present research, we further demonstrated that situational materialism can increase both Chinese and American women's self-objectification tendency. Nevertheless, future research should devote more effort to investigate the development of self-objectification and its effects on women's mental and physical health in different cultures. Our study was not without limitations which could open avenues for future research. Specifically, we used women's purchasing tendency for appearance-related products as an index of their motivation for self-objectification (Teng et al., 2015). However, purchasing tendency might be part of measuring some aspect of consumerism as participants were asked about "purchasing" the product. Although previous research demonstrated that individuals' psychological needs and behavioral intentions can be reflected in the products that they would like to choose or purchase (e.g., Zhong & Liljenquist, 2006; Chen et al., 2013), this measure is not as direct as an index of appearance management intention, such as the acceptance of cosmetic surgery, used in previous studies (Calogero et al., 2010). Therefore, future research should consider using more direct measures of women's appearance management intentions and behaviors. Moreover, although the measures of self-objectification tendency indicated satisfactory reliability in the present Chinese samples, they need to be validated in more broad Chinese samples due to the different cultural, political, and economic contexts in China. References Ashkar, L. M., & Oltmann, H. (2011). The effect of priming materialism on women's responses to thin-ideal media. *British Journal of Social Psychology*, 112, 514-521. Barling, J. L. (1990). 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Hyperscale data centers perpetuate this materialistic worldview through endless expansion in face of the suffering of both local communities and the environment in favor of the material attachment of digital capital.

Kollar 26' [Justin Kollar, Department of Architecture, College of Design and Engineering @ National University of Singapore, "GOVERNING THE CLOUD: Infrastructural Statecraft and the Political Ecology of Digital Expansion in Oregon" *SATS: Northern European Journal of Philosophy*, 20 April 2026, <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/full/10.1111/1468-2427.70098>] aa 🌐

Oregon's wave of data center and semiconductor projects shows how cloud capitalism reorganizes resource systems and territorial governance.

Examining Amazon, Google, and Intel, the article traces how fiscal incentives, utility programs, and land-use instruments are recalibrated to secure hyperscale loads. Through a political-ecological lens, it shows governance shifting from public deliberation to contractual and executive venues, including PPAs, special-service tariffs, confidentiality agreements, and expedited siting, facilitating rapid buildout while externalizing socio-ecological costs to municipalities and ecosystems. Case studies in The Dalles, Morrow/Umatilla, and Hillsboro demonstrate how 'systems-integration' by state and utility actors couples energy, water, and land as a single infrastructure, narrows transparency and contestation, and locks local institutions into long-duration commitments. These arrangements privatize control and returns while socializing risk and ecological harm, producing durable dependencies with diminishing local benefit. The article advances urban political ecology and infrastructure studies by theorizing a digital metabolic regime and by specifying infrastructural dependency as an engineered modality of power. The study concludes that governing digital expansion requires reintegrating energy–water–land assessment, restoring disclosure and public standing in decision

venues, and tying incentives to verifiable performance and community benefit. Beneath the veneer of frictionless digital exchange, the global cloud is grounded in vast and uneven material infrastructures. In Oregon's 'Silicon Forest', the expansion of data centers and semiconductor fabrication facilities reveals how the digital economy depends on an intensive remaking of territorial governance, utility systems, and ecological relations. The dematerialized, placeless infrastructure of the cloud is, in fact, a project of territorial extraction and political transformation. Cloud capital—the fusion of platform-based accumulation with the infrastructural and material demands of digital systems—reshapes urban-regional landscapes through a new alignment of corporate, state, and financial power. Understanding these shifts requires an analytic frame that links digital infrastructures to wider political, economic, and ecological transformations. Oregon's recent experience offers a concentrated view of a broader global pattern of uneven development and extraction.

These transformations have intensified in the current political moment. Since 2025, AI industrial strategy at the federal level has accelerated the restructuring of US energy, environmental, contracting, and land-use governance to fast-track data center infrastructure. 1 Framed as a national security imperative, this strategy has deployed permitting reforms, executive emergency powers, and regulatory rollbacks to prioritize rapid development while externalizing social and ecological costs onto ratepayers, local governments, and the environment. Federal agencies—including the US Environmental Protection Agency—have increasingly positioned themselves as facilitators, promoting measures such as water-reuse schemes and flexible emissions pathways to meet rising infrastructure demand. Coupled with state and local shifts, these moves entrench corporate access to energy, land, and water while weakening mechanisms for public oversight and deliberation. The foundations for these policies were laid well before 2025. In the late 2010s and early 2020s, surging demand for energy-intensive AI compute and cloud services, coupled with the CHIPS Acts, positioned semiconductor fabrication and digital infrastructure as pillars of US industrial policy. Oregon, once oriented to agriculture, timber, and post–Cold War deindustrialization, pivoted toward high tech as state and local governments increasingly acted as systems integrators for cloud and chip expansion. Beyond conventional subsidies, they fast-tracked permits, pre-empted land-use protections, reconfigured water and power provisioning, and signed long-term, contract-anchored service commitments to secure hyperscale loads for Amazon, Google, Intel, and their suppliers.

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Programs designed for high-wage manufacturing thus came to underwrite capital-intensive, labor-sparse infrastructure, leaving communities with durable utility and fiscal obligations for uncertain long-run gains. These shifts reveal a deeper transformation under cloud capitalism. Rather than merely regulating industry, the state increasingly acts as a 'systems integrator,' coupling energy, water, and land as contractual assets and engineering path-dependent infrastructural dependencies that privatize control and returns while socializing risk and ecological harm. These dynamics materialize differently across the cloud supply chain, which clarifies their territorial effects. Semiconductor fabrication plants (fabs) and hyperscale data centers both consume water and electricity at the scale of small cities, yet fab anchor supplier ecosystems and stable employment, while data centers create few jobs and convert local utilities into dedicated service providers for a handful of private loads. Meeting these always-on baselines bundles grid upgrades, water entitlements, and land conversions into a single planning problem, provoking backlash over rate hikes, water stress, and infrastructure crowd-out. Recent contests—ranging from zoning defiance that halted a multibillion-dollar project in Peculiar, Missouri, to a voter recall that stopped a major proposal in Cascade Locks, Oregon—signal the rising salience of these costs. At the same time, the decisive arena is shifting upward: because authority over electricity, siting, and water is state-mediated, legislatures are fast-tracking interconnections and pre-empting local systems integration model even where municipal consent is contested. A restructuring of infrastructural governance embeds extractive spatial logics within public planning. Marketed as immaterial or 'green,' cloud infrastructure depends on negative energy, land, and water hinterlands, disproportionately impacting rural and peri-urban territories (Digout and Lopez, 2019; Farmer, 2023; Mostafaei and Saltzman, 2025). Data centers and fabs now compete with communities for scarce water, land, and power, often advancing under loosened oversight and minimal public input. These entanglements raise fundamental questions that drive this study: who governs critical infrastructural flows under cloud capitalism, and how are public institutions repurposed to serve private accumulation strategies? The Oregon case shows how the expansion of cloud capital restructures territorial governance, erodes democratic accountability, and embeds corporate control within the everyday management of energy, water, and land. This article contributes to discourse in urban political ecology (UPe) and infrastructure studies in three linked ways. First, extending UPe's metabolic lens (Bryman et al., 2006; Swyngedouw, 2006), it specifies a digital metabolic regime in which data centers and fabs reconfigure coupled energy–water–land flows, shifting socio-ecological costs to rural and peri-urban territories while 'green' narratives obscure these transfers. Second, building on work on opacity and exception in digital infrastructures (Amore, 2018; Bridges, 2024; Brodie et al., 2024), it shows how governance shifts in practice from public forums to contractual and executive venues—PPAs, confidentiality agreements, utility dockets, and gubernatorial instruments—where transparency and contestation are constrained. Third, to paraphrase Amore (2018: 9), the aim of 'wrest[ing] the cloud into an intelligible form' is a central political task to achieve accountability and oversight. Third, it foregrounds infrastructural dependency as a modality of power. Once budgets, grids, and water systems are tuned to hyperscale loads, exit costs steepen, and political choice narrows, understanding the need to replicate planning and regulation to address the digital economy's socio-ecological footprint. The analysis proceeds through three interrelated empirical sites that map the architecture of this regime. In The Dalles, Google's data centers have reweighted the municipal budget and hydro infrastructural regime while pushing key usage data behind claims of confidentiality. In Morrow and Umatilla Counties, Amazon's expansion has intensified emissions and grid dependencies, with a rural cooperative purchasing fossil-heavy power to meet surging loads even as new renewable projects are announced. In Hillsboro, Intel's manufacturing drive has catalyzed statutory mechanisms to override land-use protections and expand urban growth boundaries in the name of industrial competitiveness. Across these cases, cloud capital consolidates its territorial footprint through tax policy, regulatory exception, and infrastructural investment—under the aegis of national security, innovation, and 'green' modernization. Methodology and theoretical framing This study adopts a conjunctural approach to make sense of the current transformational moment in the political economy of infrastructure in Oregon (and globally). By conjecture, I mean the alignment of elements that usually move on different timescales—federal industrial strategy and permitting reforms, state land-use and utility instruments, investment and market cycles, and firm siting decisions—whose entanglement is reorganizing energy, water, and land. In this spirit, conjunctural analysis is 'focused on the analysis of politically salient situations, places, and moments,' working to disentangle intersecting and articulated sources of conditioning and causality 'while remaining legibly situated in space and time' (Peck, 2023: 402). Thus, rather than treating The Dalles, Umatilla–Morrow, and Hillsboro as discrete cases, I read them as co-constituted sites within a single articulating situation, each illustrating how similar strategies meet hyperscale demand under different local conditions but operationalized within a regional and planetary system. The methods and sources reflect this conjunctural approach. I analyze public records and budgets, utility and commission filings, legislative testimony and statutes, company documents, local and national reporting, and site-specific studies. Using fiscal records, regulatory filings, and investigative reporting collected between 2023 and 2025, I map how governance over infrastructure and land use is being restructured across financial, legal, and resource systems. Because the conjuncture is multi-sited and multiscalar, documents from municipal councils, cooperative and investor-owned utilities, state agencies, regional power markets, and federal programs are read together rather than in isolation. Although qualitative, the approach emphasizes reproducibility by privileging publicly verifiable sources, while acknowledging that data availability and granularity vary by site. Viewed conjuncturally, Oregon's expansion of data centers and semiconductor facilities provides a sharp vantage on broader shifts in capitalism's spatial organization, infrastructural governance, and state power. Digital capitalism does not transpire alone—it takes form through energy, land, and water intensive systems rooted in specific regions. These material demands expose the institutional arrangements that sustain the 'cloud,' a formation I call here cloud capital: the fusion of platform accumulation with the physical infrastructures and regulatory alignments that make it possible. Far from immaterial, the cloud depends on vast networks of electricity, cooling water, land siting, and transmission corridors (Burrington, 2014; Hu, 2016; Hogan and Vonderau, 2019; Narayan, 2022). Recent scholarship traces these material underpinnings, showing how data center development relies on localized 'spatial fixes'—stable utility supply, permissive regulation, and favorable fiscal regimes—to secure capital investment (Digout and Lopez, 2019; Furlong, 2021; Brodie et al., 2024; Edwards et al., 2024). From urban relocation hubs to rural hyperscale campuses, data centers now reconfigure land-use systems and embed themselves within power plants, substations, fiber routes, and water networks, extending resource hinterlands deep into rural regions and the global South (Pitts et al., 2015; Al-Kor et al., 2022; Mostafaei and Saltzman, 2025). Building on urban metabolism in UPe (Pejman et al., 2006; Swyngedouw, 2006), I conceptualize a digital metabolic regime through these interrelated mechanisms. The first concerns how infrastructure reconfigures energy, water, and land as coupled rather than separate systems. Hyperscale, always-on operations integrate electricity supply, cooling water, and land siting into a single planning problem: new interconnections require new cooling and effluent routes; water entitlements demand pumping power and thermal rejection; land conversions necessitate transmission capacity and heat venting. This coupling incurs per-urban and rural areas as low-capacity yet highly expensive hinterlands—intensive zones of computation serving urban cores. Extending UPe's metabolic lens to digital infrastructures also reveals how 'green' or carbon-neutral efficiency narratives obscure and displace socio-ecological costs across territories (Pagan, 2015; 2018; Tan, 2019). These transformations are not just technical but are politically secured through incentives, preferential tariffs, and public-private arrangements that align multi-agency governance around hyperscale demands. The second mechanism involves a recasting of governance from jurisdictional forums to contractual and executive instruments. Statutes, hearings, and public votes persist in form, the bonding decisions increasingly reside in power purchase agreements, confidentiality clauses, special-service contracts, utility dockets, and executive authorities enabled by statute. These venues narrow transparency, public standing, and opportunities for contestation (Amore, 2018; Bridges, 2024; Brodie et al., 2024). Siting projects in suburban business parks or repurposed industrial zones—shielded by 'trade secret' claims and fragmented oversight—further insulates them from comprehensive review and obscures cumulative, cross-sector impacts (Holt and Vonderau, 2017; Pickens, 2018; Digout and Lopez, 2019; Brodie, 2020; Liberton et al., 2021; Farmer, 2023). Through such contracts, local decisions become bound to translocal corporate and developer agreements, shifting leverage beyond any single jurisdiction. In effect, the coupled resource flows identified earlier are now governed through instruments that increasingly make traditional planning and regulatory frameworks ill-suited to the scale and interdependence of cloud infrastructure. The third mechanism frames infrastructural dependency as a modality of power, produced by load profiles, resource coupling, and financialization. Classic accounts place infrastructure at the core of state power (Pergam, 1990; Graham and Marvin, 2001; Mitchell, 2002; Larkin, 2013). Here, dependency is not incidental but engineered. Hyperscale's base-load shift utilities from managing peaks to delivering persistent, contract-anchored service at the scale of a small city. Because energy, water, and land are coupled, a commitment in one domain cascades into binding obligations in the others. These linkages create systemic dependencies that expand with market growth and expose utilities and municipalities to volatility when demand or resource conditions change. Financialization then converts offshore capital, tax credits, and renewable procurements into asset-class returns—in part via advanced projects, private equity vehicles, and public pension capital (O'Neill, 2019; Braun and Christophers, 2024; Christophers, 2024). This results in rising net costs for local authorities, the migration of revenue and control rights

Despite these investments, even newly available renewable energy is still insufficient to support data-center demand, let alone to fully decarbonize cloud services.

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The **three cases—Google** in The Dalles, **Amazon** in Morrow and Umatilla Counties, and **Intel** in Hillsboro—**demonstrate** how **digital capitalism's infrastructural demands** are **reorganizing** Oregon's **territorial governance**. While **framed as engines of regional growth**, the **economic benefits** of these projects largely **flow to** distant **corporate centers** and **AI users rather than** to the **rural** and **peri-urban** communities that **host** them.

[illegible]

membership territories (source: Western Energy Markets, 2026). Third, these dynamics crystallize infrastructural dependency as a modality of power: By converting utilities into constant suppliers for energy-intensive operations and binding those commitments across energy, water, and land systems, cloud capital entrenches asymmetric relationships that privilege private flexibility over public capacity. Utilities such as Unirio Electric and PGE, though institutionally distinct, are now structurally reliant on a handful of hyperscale clients whose loads dominate forecasting, procurement, and investment decisions. These dependencies are actively engineered through financial instruments—PPAs, build-transfer leases, and green bond issuances—that transform utilities into intermediaries for global capital flows. Crucially, these agreements are often signed not by recognizable corporate entities but by shell subsidiaries—Amazon's Vada or Google's Design LLC—that capture tax incentives and isolate liability. Public records typically list only these intermediaries, legally obscuring who bears ultimate responsibility if projects are delayed, downgraded, or abandoned. This opacity masks significant financial and regulatory risk. Throughout 2025, financial commentators have begun to warn of overcapacity in AI infrastructure, noting parallels to earlier cycles of overbuild in energy and telecom sectors (Elder, 2025; Ip, 2025; Lutz and Lichtenberg, 2025) followed by the Bank of England and the International Monetary Fund in October 2025. If cloud demand slows, subsidiaries could default, triggering cascading liabilities. Historical precedents suggest how this might unfold (although present interdependencies are much more complex). In 2018, FirstEnergy Solutions sought to abandon long-term PPAs during bankruptcy, revealing the fragility of supposedly binding contracts. Earlier deregulation waves saw utilities recover billions in stranded costs from ratepayers through surcharges—costs that effectively socialized private risk. When infrastructure financed for expansion becomes underutilized, local budgets shrink, pension funds lose value, and ecological stresses persist as utilities continue operating facilities built for vanished demand.

Dependency, in this sense, is not merely a side effect of digital expansion but a mechanism of power that aligns state institutions with the imperatives of accumulation while foreclosing alternative pathways for public or ecological governance. The net effect of this emergent digital metabolic regime in the cases in Oregon is to ensure efficiency and certainty for capital while eroding democratic control.

The same contracts that stabilize markets for investors constrain the capacity of states and communities to redirect infrastructure toward public or ecological ends. When downturns reveal hidden obligations, the public inherits systems optimized for private expansion but likely ill-suited for collective resilience. In this light, the Oregon case reads less as an exception and more as an early signal of how these liabilities travel through territory. Conclusion At first glance, Oregon's hydropower, protective land use law, and progressive energy policy positioned it as an ideal test case for sustainable digital growth. Yet even under these favorable conditions, cloud expansion has produced scarcity, opacity, and new dependencies. If one of the best-prepared US states struggles to manage the strain, the implications for less-prepared regions are starker. Utilities are already recalibrating to this demand: investor-owned and public providers plan to spend hundreds of billions of dollars on the grid in 2025 and more than USD 1.1 trillion through 2029 to accommodate rising load from AI/data centers and broader electrification (EE, 2025). Governments are matching this shift by reshaping energy policy around data-center reliability, in some cases reviving fossil assets and fast-tracking approvals. Georgia has reversed coal-plant closures, Pennsylvania and West Virginia are leaning into natural gas, and the United Kingdom and several US states have created industry-led councils to accelerate permitting for energy and data-center projects for competitiveness and national security. Oregon thus serves not as a leading indicator of a wider reorganization of territorial development around the infrastructural demands of cloud capital. The shifts illustrated in the Oregon cases extend urban political ecology into the domain of digital infrastructure (see Cugurullo et al., 2025) by showing that data centers and fabs inaugurate a new phase of metabolic urbanization in which energy, water, and land are deliberately planned as interoperable service layers for rapid capital accumulation. Whereas classical UPE emphasized how urbanization externalizes environmental costs, the contemporary problem is that infrastructural integration now internalizes corporate priorities within the state itself. In this context, metabolism no longer describes only the circulation of resources sustaining urban life; it also encompasses the

infrastructures that provision 'national computing power' for geopolitical competition (Kollar and Stokols, 2025). As agencies are remade to operate as infrastructural arms of digital capitalism, the material outcomes—drought intensification, grid saturation, and farmland loss—follow directly from, and cannot be separated from, this institutional reconfiguration.

For planning and infrastructure studies, Oregon's trajectory reveals how the state's role has evolved from regulator to systems integrator. Under the imperatives of competitiveness and national security, state agencies now coordinate land, energy, and water as an integrated platform for private investment. Utilities and municipalities have become intermediaries bound to the baseloads of hyperscale firms, while fiscal stability increasingly hinges on volatile technology markets. Even as new policies such as the POWER Act and microgrid legislation attempt to rebalance cost and control, public institutions are locked into reproducing private digital infrastructures.

This study contributes to long-standing debates on privatization and state capacity by showing how governance itself becomes infrastructural—distributed across contracts, tariffs, and delegated authorities rather than centralized decision-making. Addressing these challenges requires rebuilding state capacity to govern coupled infrastructures at the scales where decisions now materialize. Acknowledging the need for variegated pathways of resistance and pressure amidst rising authoritarian politics, three policy directions follow. First, transparency and permitting must be integrated. Approvals for large digital facilities should jointly assess energy, water, and land impacts and tie incentives to verified performance metrics for emissions, withdrawals, and conversion. Second, the binding terms of expansion must return to partial public oversight through mandatory disclosure of load profiles, volumetric use, and cost-allocation frameworks, alongside community-benefit and accountability clauses. Third, risk and cost must be rebalanced by linking tax abatements and grid investments to measurable public returns and protecting small users through proportional capacity payments or standby charges. Where state pre-emption curtails local power, rules must still provide veto or compensation mechanisms for affected tribal and agricultural communities. Ultimately, Oregon's experience underscores that under cloud capitalism, infrastructural politics is less about expanding capacity than deciding whose world's public systems are built to sustain. The decisive choices—how energy is allocated, who bears cost (and risk), and where authority resides—now occur in executive and contractual venues optimized for speed, not deliberation. Re-politicizing the cloud thus demands institutions capable of governing digital metabolic regimes as coupled systems and restoring democratic oversight to decisions currently made in technical and financial backrooms. Only by relocating these choices into arenas of public accountability can technological modernization be reconciled with ecological limits and the collective right to shape the infrastructures on which contemporary life depends.

Materialism violates Buddhist ethics by embodying a manifestation of tanha, entrenching an ignorant cycle of insatiable desire and perpetuating existential suffering, opposing the Buddhist pursuit of spiritual liberation through the transcendence of attachment. We must affirm to interrupt this cycle and embrace liberation.

Simão '19 [João Simão; 2019; professor at the Universidade Aberta with a Doctor of Philosophy studying Business Ethics; The International Journal of Religion and Spirituality in Society, "Some Tensions between Capitalism and Buddhism: A Reflection from McMindfulness," vol. 9, epositorioaberto.uab.pt/entities/publication/1dca7c14-72ab-4806-b94d-a479b3ab7407/request-a-copy?bitstream=07dd7462-d056-4090-be8d-dc83e4b95f9a]

Tensions between Buddhism and Capitalism

In this section some notable differences between the Buddhist mind-set and the capitalist method of organising society economically are highlighted. The purpose is to show the impossibility of conciliation between ethics and the correct understanding of Buddhism, on the one hand, and capitalism, on the other hand, which makes it impossible for western society to adopt Buddhist principles, especially a broad and integrated understanding of sati. The Merriam-Webster (n.d.) online dictionary defines capitalism as: "an economic system characterized by private or corporate ownership of capital goods, by investments that are determined by private decision, and by prices,

production, and the distribution of goods that are determined mainly by competition in a free market.” The definition refers to an economic system that (i) favours private property, (ii) whose accumulation generates incomes that finance investment for the benefit of the private deciders, holders of capital, (iii) in a competitive market and free of public intervention that determines what to produce, the quantity, the distribution, and the prices. In the following points the article discusses how a system with these characteristics conflicts with ancestral Buddhist teachings, highlighting three fundamental concepts: one of the consequences of the nonexistence of a self (anatta) is the impossibility of possession, which blasts the concept of property; consumption, other than that necessary for spiritual development, comes from illusory desire (tanha), which must be restrained and overcome; beings are not born free because there is an endless action-reaction chain that conditions them (kamma)—true freedom is achieved through a process of self-awareness, development, and awakening the consciousness. Possession and the Non-self The doctrine of the non-self (anatta) states that the idea of the self or soul as a permanent and material entity is an illusion. What exist are aggregated phenomena in constant mutation which, separately or combined, are not a true entity ego or personality (Nyanatiloka 1967).⁴ Attachment to the entity of the self is the root of all ignorance. It is a fabricated interpretation that one is conditioned to see as consistent and real. It is thought that this body with this form exists and has sensations and perceptions; but what Buddhism invokes is that there is “no independent entity that qualifies as the self to be found anywhere, either inside or outside the body” (Khyentse 2008, 60). The self does not reside in bodies, sensations, perceptions, actions, or consciousness. As it does not exist, attachment to the illusory self is the source of ignorance that drives compulsive behaviour, pain, suffering, and disappointment. Nyanatiloka (1967, 15) considers this “the fundamental Buddhist doctrine not found in any other religious teaching or philosophical system.” An interesting consequence of anatta is that, as there is no self, the notion of possession makes no sense. In order for “possession” or “having” to exist, there has to be someone who possesses or has, but as there is no self, there is no one who possesses or has. As there is no one who has thoughts, but only thoughts, there is no one who possesses objects, but there are only objects. ⁵ The idea of a possessor who possesses is due to **ignorance** and illusion. Puligandla and Puhakka (1970, 347) conclude that: Buddhism has little use for any form of capitalist ideology or ethic, for which the notions of property, possession, and ownership are central. The notion of property rights has no positive meaning in the Buddhist way of thinking. On the contrary, an individual who concerns himself with accumulating property, however honest and rightful the means he employs for doing so, is a victim of the worst form of ignorance, for he fails to see that by collecting things and attaching himself to them he becomes enchained and loses his freedom. Insofar as the high value which capitalism places on property and the desire to possess reinforces and perpetuates the ignorance which Buddhism tries to eliminate root and branch, Buddhism takes its stand in opposition to capitalism. As non-possession is a result of the non-self, Buddhism and capitalism are in opposition, as the latter favours possession and private property, while the former teaches detachment. Without the possession of goods, the capitalist system cannot exist, since it is based on income and investment that leads to the reproduction of these goods and the acquisition of new ones, or rather the accumulation; in order to afterwards be reinvested and to continue the cycle. Consumption and Desire Buddhist wisdom distinguishes between two types of desire: tanha and chanda. While chanda refers to the appropriate consumption of goods and services in order to satisfy basic needs and the true personal well-being of ourselves and others, tanha is the consumption that satisfies sensory pleasures and gratify the ego, and is therefore unnecessary and wrong. The second Noble Truth clarifies the existence of three sort of tanha: the desire for sensory pleasures (kama tanha), the desire to become (bhava tanha), and the desire to get rid of (vibhava tanha): What is the Noble Truth of the Origin of Suffering? It is craving which renews being and is accompanied by relish and lust, relishing this and that: in other words, craving for sensual desires, craving for being, craving for non-being. But whereon does this craving arise and flourish? Wherever there is what seems lovable and gratifying, thereon it arises and flourishes. (Samyutta Nikaya LVI, 11 as cited in Sumedho 2011, 19) For the purposes of the discussion about consumption, kama tanha is emphasised. Sumedho (2011, 19) describes it as “wanting sense pleasures through the body or the other senses and always seeking things to excite or please your senses.” But notice that desire itself is not the cause of suffering. Suffering happens because there is attachment to desire. Desire comes from ignorance (avijja), because it derives from attachment. Desire is the reason for consumption. In the current socioeconomic model, desires are encouraged and created by marketing campaigns, by programmed obsolescence, by what is in fashion, generating superfluous consumption. Thus, desires are only limited by scarcity (of the desired good or the income to buy it). According to Buddhist teaching, desires must be controlled by moderation and by the pursuit of genuine well-being. Here, consumption must be accompanied by a real purpose of supplying basic, personal, and collective needs, avoiding unnecessary consumption in tune with chanda. Consumption is seen as a means to achieve the ultimate goal of enhancing human development. For example, the consumption of food aims to nourish the consumer

physically and mentally so that they can develop spiritually, not primarily for the pleasure it provides. Consequently, the consumption provided by desire that does not contribute to personal development is *tanha*. In other words, non-consumption can contribute to our well-being. Consumption is an essential macroeconomic variable in modern economics and capitalism. Schumacher (1973, 58) states that: “[Modern economics] considers consumption to be the sole end and purpose of all economic activity, taking the factors of production—land, labour, and capital—as the means.” Many government policies rely on consumer incentives as the driver of economic growth (Chai 2018), with the dissemination of campaigns for personal loans for the acquisition of consumer goods. The contrast of Buddhist thought to the consumption-based capitalist system is evident. Lorentz (2001, 193) even points out that it is impossible to harmonise a Western consumer society and a sincere practice of Buddhism, and quotes a definition of consumerism from 1997 from the International Network of Engaged Buddhists (INEB): Consumerism: the dominant culture of a modernizing invasive industrialism which stimulates—yet can never satisfy—the urge for a strong sense of self to overlay the angst and sense of lack in the human condition [i.e., impermanence, suffering, etc.]. As a result, goods, services, and experiences are consumed beyond any reasonable need. This undermines the eco-system, the quality of life, particularly in traditional cultures and communities, and the possibility of spiritual liberation. The capitalist system does not distinguish between needs and wants or desires, and individuals do not satisfy only their basic needs in order to live properly. For a market with liquidity, greed for goods and services (one of the forms of attachment) is stimulated and required—to such a degree that it has become a system of values and beliefs, in which the market can be seen as a God: consumption has become a spiritual necessity that supposedly would lead to salvation through the satisfaction of desires (Loy 1997). But as desires are insatiable, salvation will never be attained.

Affirm to take refuge in Dharma and embrace the Eightfold Path. Without the rejection of impermanent pleasures we remain ignorant and suffer. Affirmation is to instead welcome the Buddhist invitation and join the Path of Liberation.

Magee ’19 [Rhonda; 2019; faculty member at University of San Francisco Law School; Buddhism and Whiteness, “Taking and Making Refuge in Racial [Whiteness] Awareness and Racial Justice Work,” pp. 254-261]

PART 1: TAKING REFUGE AS A PATHWAY TO RACIAL AWARENESS

Taking Refuge: The Buddhist Invitation to Commit to the Path of Liberation

“To seek refuge is to look for a place that is safe, a place we can rely on.”² To practice in this tradition, whatever the particular sect or stream, is to embrace the practice of taking refuge in what have been called the Three Jewels: the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Sangha:

I take refuge in the Buddha, the one who shows me the way in this life.

I take refuge in the Dharma, the way of understanding and love.

I take refuge in the Sangha, the community that lives in harmony and awareness.

To practice meditation and the allied disciplines is to experience refuge, the sense of being engaged in a reliable way of being with reality, a way of coming to terms with the true nature of our existence, all in an effort to experience liberation from suffering. Fundamentally, refuge may be found within, wherever we are.

And yet, importantly, as embodied beings, our experiences of suffering vary depending on the circumstances and situations in which we live and experience the world. The Buddha taught us about the suffering experienced by each of us as a result of the arising of a sense of a permanent self in a world where nothing is permanent, and the “separate self” is fundamentally an illusion. I refer to this as existential suffering because it is a feature of our existence as human beings.³ Less emphasized in the teachings as they have been translated for Western audiences and practitioners of mindfulness are the ways that the Buddha recognized the suffering that was caused by the trainings of our culture and social structures.

In the culture of contemporary America, pervasive, informal trainings in racism and other forms of social identity–based **bias are deeply embedded and** still **powerful**. **Racism**—the belief in essential differences in human beings tied in some way to the defined races through notions of biology and culture, and **the ideology of differential human value** and worth **associated with** the notion of **racial difference**—is taught and practiced (most often in subtle ways, but not always) **as a** broad and central cultural **commitment**.

Racism operates on personal, interpersonal, and structural and systemic levels. For those **whom** racist ideas have cast as subordinate or inferior, **racism results in** additional or surplus **suffering**—suffering **beyond that which we all feel as** a result of the development of the sense of **the ego** and the separate, fixed self. In our society, **Whites have been legally, economically, and culturally privileged as presumptively deserving of inclusion** and better than-fair treatment.

Non-Whites have **suffered** the challenge of establishing their **right** to be treated with equal respect, dignity, and concern.⁴

Because race and racism are prevalent yet very often un-acknowledged forms of suffering in our midst, **Taking Refuge** in the path and **practices association with mindfulness and meditation** implicitly supports us in both seeing clearly and **healing from** the particular **suffering associated with** and caused by the practices of **race and racism**. The personal path of practice may support us, then, in **developing racial awareness** and in living in a way that **promotes the end of race-based suffering in the world**.

Mindfulness and Blindspots

When we reflect on the nature of **racism**—in its personal, interpersonal, and systemic or structural dimensions—we see that it **is a subtle and complex** nexus of thought, emotion, and sensation that supports degrees of consciousness and unconsciousness about who we are and how the respect we owe one another **creates** unnecessary or **surplus suffering in the world**.

Research confirms that bias—a subtle and often unintentional form of racism—is ubiquitous. And with bias comes what sociologists call **“blind spots”**: the invisibility or unconsciousness to us of the ways in which we **discount some groups** and may **discriminate against them** or their members **in our everyday lives**.

The problem of racism (or bias) presents both a challenge and an opportunity for practitioners of Buddhism with an interest in social justice. While some evidence suggests that practices associated with Buddhism, including mindfulness of breath and lovingkindness, can assist in minimizing bias and discrimination, the research in this area is nascent and certainly not yet definitive.⁶ Moreover, both research efforts in this area and anecdotal evidence suggest reason for caution.⁷ For these reasons, we need to look to more than our mindfulness practices for assistance in minimizing the operation of bias in our lives and increasing our capacity to make refuge for others in our practice communities.

In short, mindfulness and lovingkindness practices may be helpful, but these practices alone cannot yet be deemed effective in eliminating racism in ourselves and in our communities.

The Allied Disciplines

Buddhist teachers traditionally **guide practitioners to engage in mindfulness meditation** as part of a commitment to **taking refuge in the Buddha, the Dharma**, and the Sangha. Contrary to many Western mindfulness meditation programs, such Buddhist teachers offer mindfulness meditation **as** part of a **commitment to Buddhist practice**, learning, and perhaps religious engagement **through the Eightfold Path**. In traditional approaches, mindfulness **meditation is offered as** one **part of Buddhist practice** and study. It is worth noting that the attention that mindfulness meditation and related practices have received in the contemporary US context is not representative of how mindfulness is situated in most traditional Buddhist contexts.

<<CONDENSED, NONE OMITTED>>

Moreover, in addition to engaging in mindfulness meditation, practitioners are asked to study and practice much more. Consistent with language used by at least some traditional teachers, I refer to these other practices and commitments as the allied disciplines. The allied disciplines traditionally include ethical commitments, the discipline of studying both with a teacher and through the study of texts, and the practice of meditation in a practice community. However, in my years of teaching and learning about race and racism, I came to see that addressing racism would require more. Thus, I began to explore what particular disciplines might be proposed as appropriate “allies” for the work of redressing racism. Research has shown that in addition to bringing people from different backgrounds together—designating and integrating—engaging people from diverse backgrounds in meaningful contact minimizes bias. Moreover, evidence indicates that colorblind efforts may do more harm than good. While well-meaning in most cases, such efforts serve as barriers to learning about race and racism in our lives, leading to the perpetuation of under-examined racially disparate outcomes. Instead, effective training in multicultural understanding and anti-racism counsels addressing and countering racism effectively. Therefore, in my own work as a teacher of both anti-racist education and mindfulness, I have explored incorporating selected texts, instruction on concepts and practices, all of which aim to make the work of addressing bias through awareness practice more effective. The particular texts may vary. The point is that each of us who are in positions to shape practice and learning communities have an obligation to provide resources—to teachers and participants—that deepen our collective understanding of how the marginalized in our communities may perceive the world. We have an obligation to seek to expand the lenses through which we view the world and thereby increase the level of awareness of the potential for discrimination that is inherent in ourselves, our communities, and institutions. Exploring Social Identity, Culture, and Cultural History as Racialized Aspects of Everyday Life To support the deepening of our understanding of race and racism, exploring the construction of social identity is essential. For the purposes of this chapter, I define identity with reference to two aspects—personal and social—which sometimes overlap completely, but may sometimes overlap only tangentially. Personal identity arises in response to the question of how one defines oneself (“Who am I?”). Social identity arises through the ways that we are defined by the outside world, how our embodiments link to the socially, culturally defined categories by which we have come to make sense of the world. And for our purposes here, I define culture as recurring patterns of behavior and liturgy within a given group of people passed down through implicit and explicit teaching, often over generations and, in particular, geographic space. Buddhist philosophy of the self as a mental construct harmonizes in many ways with Western social psychological notions of the socially constructed self. However, as taught in many Western settings, Buddhism often does not address the social self very much, beyond noting its illusory nature. We tend not to hear much, within contemporary Western Buddhist convert or mindfulness settings, about cultural patterns of oppression and privilege as aspects of how we construct the self. One notable departure is the teaching of Tsoknyi Rinpoche, whose description of the “social I”—that sense of the self that comes into being as a result of our lived experiences in the social realm—parallels of Western social psychological notions of socially contextualized, socially embedded identity. And Tsoknyi Rinpoche’s concept of the “social I”—the aspect 238 Rhonda V. Magee of the social I that can be deployed in service of a more compassionate world—may be particularly helpful in deepening our understanding of why it is important to engage in mindfulness of our racial identities in the world. In the United States, dominant culture and prevailing notions of race and racial identity are and have been for centuries intimately intertwined. Since the settler-colonial era, US culture has categorized individuals and groups according to “race,” and, more specifically, has defined “white” as the dominant racial identity over all others. As such, to be racially defined—or “racialized”—as white is to be identified with the lived experience of significant racial privilege when compared to the experience afforded via-a-via all other racialized bodies. White Privilege is often subtle. It is often expressed not in what one experiences but in what one is, by virtue of one’s whiteness, likely not given to experience (such as the presumption of criminality, common in the experience of those racialized Black, or the presumption of foreignness, common in the experience of those racialized as either Asian or Latino). And because each and all of us are consciously or subconsciously trained in White Supremacy and in the cultural contents and imperatives of Whiteness, each and all of us benefit from practices aimed at raising awareness of race and racism in the construction of the self. The construction of Whiteness as dominant emerged (and yet emerges) through the interlocking effects of more or less intentional racializing projects within institutions such as law, religion, politics, science, education, and more. The personal-systemic actions of these institutions combined to create, legitimize, and reinforce the master narrative of White Supremacy, originally as a justification of the systems, politics, and practices of conquest, slavery, and colonization, through which Whiteness was imbued with not merely symbolic cultural value, but substantive material value. As a result, Whiteness has operated as the “standard” human experience, the norm against which all other experiences within the dominant institutions of society are compared and measured. And even into the contemporary era, its substantive, material value has been maintained its currency, compounded by the invisibility of its dynamics for most of the post-Civil Rights era. Because it has been both the dominant experience and the experience of the numerical majority, Whiteness has been the least examined among all experiences of race. It has been, in that sense, the invisible racial experience, the one racial experience defined primarily, and perhaps until quite recently, by one’s experience of never having to think about race. Most of us have encountered the laudable essay “White Privilege: Unpacking the Invisible Knapsack,” through which scholar Peggy McIntosh described her efforts to come to terms with the privileges afforded her as a result of her white skin.¹¹ The power of the essay is in its critical and insightful reflection on the fact that she had to work hard to see her while taking and Making Rights in Racial (Whiteness) 239 skin privilege, much in the way that she knew that men had to work to see how their gender afforded them often subtle privileges in the world, and the ways in which it made her life easier in relationship to people of color who did not possess such privilege. Less well known outside of critical race theory discourse is the work of Barbara Flagg, whose writings engage upon the idea of white privilege by exploring precisely how it is that the invisible experience of it, and of white racialization generally, tends to render transparent the white racial character of what appear to be “neutral” norms and standards in the legal and broader social world.¹² In using the word “transparent,” Flagg refers to “White”/unconsciousness of Whiteness, and derivatively to “White”/use of white-specific criteria of decision.” She describes the “transparency phenomenon” as “the tendency of Whites not to think about Whiteness, or about norms, behaviors, experiences or perspectives that are White specific.”¹³ White transparency contributes to the unintentional categorization, stereotyping, and marginalization of non-white-racialized people in ways that are subtle and thus require more than the usual capacity for awareness to be seen and for its effects to be sufficiently understood to disrupt. Flagg has argued, for example, that “employing transparent white norms is a form of marginalization because it ensures that non-whites will be assessed less positively than whites, and so has the consequence that whites will retain the bulk of social power and privilege.”¹⁴ Because of these attributes of white experience—the invisibility of whiteness as an identity in a white-dominated world, and the white-but-transparent and so-called neutral perspective that emerges from that invisible racial identity—the lived experience of Whiteness to those racialized as white has been compared to the experience of water to those born as fish. From the perspective of the fish immersed in water, water may be mistaken for not existing at all; rather, it is just “the way things are.” Only when one is able to gain experience of “not water” does the reality of the water in which one has been swimming come to be seen as not only real but pervasive. “Not Whiteness”—the experience of racially Othered (or “Non-White”) people in the United States—is akin to the experience of the fish that has been often thrust outside of the ocean of Whiteness that the awareness of

both Whiteness and Not Whiteness is very real. And yet because the experiences between whites and the racialized Others are so different, it is hard for us to communicate our experiences in ways that maintain a sense of common ground. It is imperative, then, that those racialized as white find ways of opening their capacity to see Whiteness as Whiteness. The teachings and practices of the Buddha provide possible pathways for those of us seeking to better understand race, racism, and the suffering they cause. In the next section, I discuss how some of those practices support a 260 Rhonda V. Magee way of being with reality that may be particularly useful in helping us understand how race and racism have shaped all of our lives.

<<PARAGRAPH INTEGRITY RESUMES>>

The Four Noble (or Ennobling) Truths

According to legend, the first teachings of the Buddha described the insights he had gained through his own practice of what would come to be known as the Middle Way. These four insights are well known to even the most novice student of Buddhism:

There is suffering.

There is a cause of suffering.

There is an end to suffering.

The end of suffering arises from following the eightfold path.

Beginning with acknowledgment of the pervasiveness of what in Pali is known as dukkha—suffering, pain, or dissatisfaction in human life, the Buddha’s teachings invite inquiry into the causes of this, and commitment to exploring ways of ending it. Suffering, the teachings suggest, is caused by three dominant reactions to the challenges of human existence—our tendencies to cling to that which is impermanent, to reject that which is present, and to remain ignorant about the true nature of reality. Suffering may be brought to an end by practicing the essential tenets of the Eightfold Path to liberation, which is comprised of Right View, Right Intention, Right Speech, Right Conduct, Right Livelihood, Right Effort, Right Mindfulness, and Right Concentration. Thus, the core of the Buddha’s teachings presents suffering as inherent in the human condition and yet capable of being overcome by any one of us by taking up the journey of the Eightfold Path, the first step of which is the development of Right View.

Kritiks allow for deeper epistemological discussion which is infinitely good for both fairness and education. Debate is a key space to have these discussions and any attempt to distract away is ignorant of the harms minority groups go through. Vote for the Kritik to encourage a shift away from traditionalist mindsets and to instead radically support a model of debate that allows for these discussions to take place.

Smith 21’ [Smith, Elijah J. Director of Debate @ Rutgers University-Newark, New Jersey, Masters in Communication and Media Studies, BA in Public and Nonprofit Administration, “The Kritik-Focus Model of Debate” U.S.A https://japan-debate-association.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/12/6thTCA2020_Proceedingspp.137-145_Smith.rev_..pdf *Proceedings of the Tokyo Conference on Argumentation, Volume 6*] ak

While this affirmed efforts to diversify debate and to validate the Kritik, it also shattered the glass ceiling over Kritik arguments and minority success in debate at-large. Uniting the Crowns spilled over to other evidentiary debate like Lincoln-Douglas, Public Forum, and some forms of College Parliamentary Debate. Moreover, representatives of the debate community, including recent National Debate Tournament Champions from traditionalist and predominantly white institutions, publicly denigrate Kritik debate and scapegoated it for a decline in participation. Others have made this same claim even though the biblical end of the event has been prophesied since at least the early 1980’s – much earlier than any modern debaters or Kritiks were even thought of (Herbeck, n.d.; Parson, 1996; Loudon, 1997). The American University remains under fire and will face renewed financial and political pressure because of the ongoing Covid-19 pandemic. The CPD community is not exempt from these concerns and will face increased visibility due the upcoming season of online debate. Together, all these things serve as a reminder to justify the learning community we have created. A reasonable fear of we who are “diversity enhancing” is that the traditionalists who disengage from us and our pedagogical goals now will not defend our programs tomorrow. Kritikal debate does not have a direct and singular academic defense of our model. Extant literature on the Kritik is focused on recording history, creating and documenting important theoretical and cultural justifications for Kritikal arguments, engaging in rhetorical criticism, responding to racial hostility, or discussing Kritik innovations (Mitchell, 1998; Haig, 2005a; Haig, 2005b;

Reid-Brinkley, 2008; Polson, 2012; Reid-Brinkley, 2012; Smith, 2013; Vincent, 2013; Alston, et.al. 2014; Dillard-Knox, 2014; James, 2017; Kelsie, 2019) My research into this question shows that the CPD community, and proponents of the Kritik specifically, spend insufficient time describing pedagogical value o those outside of our community(Llano, 2014). A priority must be to mount an internal defense of the Kritik-Focus Model (KFM) of debate. A second priority must be translating that defense to external actors. This paper will serve both goals, in part, as an addition to the literature on the Kritik that explicates some of the pedagogical benefits of the KFM. 2. LITERATURE REVIEW The Kritik is hard to define because part of its strategic and pedagogical value is that it questions everything. At its core, the Kritik is a philosophical argument introduced into a Policy Debate that questions the, “cherished assumptions of policy decision making” that undergird the Plan-Focus Model of debate (Hasian and Panetta,1998). Since its introduction in the 1980’s the Kritik has become a strategy competitors must be knowledgeable of. An opponent introducing the Kritik into a round can broadly question, “presuppositions and assumptions about rules, frameworks, structures, and systems of thought.”, to win (Bennet 1996). While there are many styles and types of Kritiks, they can be categorized into Kritik’s of language and value that are used when potentially “dangerous” words or ethical frameworks are part of an opponent’s advocacy (Bennet,1996,p 1). Early proponents of the Kritik argued that it is essential that we understand that Kritiks supplement but don’t supplant, policy analysis because, “When one implements a policy, one also implements a value system” (Gherke 98, Pg 29). The Kritik was originally introduced by the Negative team to indict an Affirmative Plan. Naturally, the Kritik pushed past that constraint and transitioned to the Affirmative. Kritikal Affirmatives follow a similar structure to the one used by PFM debates. The Affirmative team finds an inherent problem in the status quo that is causing significant harm and presents a Resolution -based change that can solve those harms*1. The Affirmative articulates their advocacy through what is called a “methodology” (or Method of change) that is advanced with a philosophical framework for evaluating the debate. Affirmative methods are often, “pragmatically grounded in the physical presence of advocates, underwritten by evidence of the advocate’s speechmaking capabilities (Gordon,1998). Kritikal Affirmative Methods are similar to plans where the Affirmative team can Proceedings of the Tokyo Conference on Argumentation, Volume 6 - 138 - still logically be held, “responsible for the consequences of their advocacy” but are vaguer in the area of the mechanism (Brovero,2019). Affirmative Methods are diverse and may be framed as demands, advocacies, or just “arguments”. The level of specified detail required for a team to win a ballot is up for debate, similarly to PFM debates, since the Negative can press for those details in cross-examination and in their speeches. It should be noted that the Plan-Focus Model planted the seeds of Kritikal arguments. When an Affirmative team justifies its Plan by raising the issue of Inherency, they are not limited to Structural (a legal barrier), Attitudinal (oppositional attitude of the American public), or Gap (absence of action in a policy area) Inherency. Affirmative teams have always had the ability to frame their arguments around existential barriers to solving the myriad problems that plague humanity, even if that barrier is humanity itself. Existential Inherency, like all other arguments, has evolved. Moreover, Policy Debate has built-in mechanisms for having debates about the norms and procedures of debate in Topicality arguments. Topicality requires constant innovation and rethinking of the boundaries of the game. The idea of reading a “topical” Plan, a mere subset of the Resolution, could represent the topic was a pre-requisite to Kritikal readings of the topic. Finally, many of Policy debate’s most successful programs are linked to Communication departments where communities of learners have always studied debate and public speaking variety of critical lenses (Goodwin,2001 Pg. 63). The development of the Kritik was inevitable; our job is to maximize the benefits of having it. An educational model is a, “blueprint for the future” (Kwong,2016). The KFM ,then, has to detail what debate looks like when the Affirmative Method is the focus of the debate rather than the Plan. In CPD, the long-standing litmus test for change is how it might affect the a year’s worth of rigorous academic debate (Wade, 1996). The most prestigious awards, outside of championships, are based on season-long excellence. Defenses of College Policy Debate’s PFM argue that a model of debate is required to meet the following 3 criteria. First, any topic worthy of debate has to be able to sustain a year’s worth of argument innovation. Teams should be able to find new arguments on both sides of the topic through intense research. Second, there must be a role for the Affirmative team. The Affirmative team should be able to defend some change to the status quo that is not morally repugnant or otherwise indefensible. Finally, there must be a role for the Negative team. They have to predict, research, and adequately respond to an Affirmative advocacy presented at any part of the season. The Negative should not be required to respond to an uncontroversial argument that is not the Resolution . I argue that the Kritik-Focus Model meets these three criteria. 3. METHOD Community-Based Action Research (CBAR) is the method used in this paper (Burns, et. al.,2011). It takes the debate community itself as a unit of analysis and documents the experience of those invested in the future of the community. It prescribes the KFM as future action for the betterment of the community. I polled 10 of the most successful coaches and debaters at the 2019 Blake Winter Invitational, a tournament with a long history of supporting diversity, to start this project. I inquired about the benefits of Kritik debate, which “Flex Teams” (those willing to have PFM and KFM debates) were most successful, and who best represented the traditionalists. In addition to the names I got from this poll, I reached out to those people I knew were doing social justice work, regardless of their ideological predispositions. I conducted 12 interviews. Three interviews were excluded; one person was too far-removed from debate. Two of the interviews created potential conflicts of interest. Because of limited space, only 6 of those interviews are used here. The others will contribute to a second paper. Each interview was performed by phone or video call, was recorded, and lasted approximately one hour. Any information relayed in the interview that I was asked to exclude was removed. Each person was presented with a

rough draft of quotes from their interview and was given the opportunity to confirm their portrayal. 4. MODEL OF DEBATE To create a blueprint, the Kritik-Focus Model must have a purpose. Proponents of **Kritik debate argue that it creates opportunity for epistemological growth** that **students do not experience elsewhere** because they are incentivized by ballots to research a wide variety of arguments that challenge their understanding of the world *1. This is consistent with Roger Solt's (1995, p. A9-10) claim that decisions in any debates represent provisional judgements that produce, "our moral and political belief system[s]". At the end of a season or a career, **each person is fundamentally transformed by the conversations they have been a part of**. Alternatively, defenders of the PFM argue that competitive equity and a fair decision is the only thing each round should represent. However, the competition for its own sake is unacceptable in an educational activity. Tiffany Dillard-Knox, Director of The University of Louisville Malcolm X Debate Society and former participant in "The Louisville Project" *2 warns us against such a mode of competition: "Competition at all costs is dangerous... Our argument was that people wanted to win and would do anything to win regardless of the dehumanizing effects of particular strategies... like the Malthus argument... it was all about winning... Competition at all costs creates harmful effects because we're not thinking about the people we are debating against..."

Prior to Kritik debaters pushing back on competition at all costs, judges would allow students to make racist, sexist, or otherwise discriminatory arguments because, as Director Dillard-Knox explains, "... literally anything went". Today, judges are willing to penalize debaters for creating a hostile environment because **competition is no longer our sole priority**. To avoid this pitfall, **KFM will prioritize that the educational environment and the growth of students over any marginal benefits of improved competition**.

The Kritik-Focus Model starts with the Affirmative team. It is their burden to choose a critical/cultural perspective based, at least partially, on academic research and apply it to the Resolution. Perspectives run the gamut from Critical Race Theory, Womanism, Latinx, and Marxist perspectives to broader theories of Ontology, Epistemology, and Cosmology. From their critical/cultural understanding of the Resolution, the Affirmative must advocate a Method of change that departs from the status quo. The Negative team has the burden of rejoinder—they must prove that the Affirmative Method is not desirable. To prove that the Affirmative is not desirable, the Negative must choose a critical/cultural perspective, evaluate the Affirmative, and respond. After a year of Kritikal debates on the Resolution, a single student would have been exposed to dozens of critical perspectives and would have a deep understanding of forgotten or sublimated histories that they do not learn anywhere else. By the end of a debate career, competitors would be incentivized to be proficient and well-read across all parts of the academy. The NDT champion, CEDA, or TOC champion would represent the team with the best ability to evaluate, apply, and articulate critical/cultural theories and methods to global problems. KFM Affirmative Methods must make a good faith effort to be tied to the topic. Opponents of this argue that this allows the Affirmative to choose an advocacy outside of the topic. I, however, am arguing that we **re-think what it means to debate the Resolution**. Those who compete under the KFM understand debatable arguments to be limited by something I call the Travel Test.

When teams are traveling to competitions and someone inquires about the topic, well-worn travelers know not to rattle off the entire Resolution. Instead, we provide the key words that describe the larger topic being debated. This year's CPD topic is Military Alliances. No proponent of KFM would be surprised to hear an Affirmative that reduces a commitment to the system of Militarism itself. This is a predictable, controversial premise for a Kritikal argument linked to the core of the topic. PFM advocates object to shifting from "The" Resolution controversy to "A" topic controversy even though they may acknowledge that many Kritikal Methods are controversial. William Repko, Director of Debate at Michigan State University explained his take on this issue: "There are **debates in critical/cultural theory** that don't center on the state but that **have a lot of clash**. At times I do see non-traditional teams run an Aff that is dipped right from the heart of a fight that's academically occurring in critical/cultural theory. To me, there would be **no excuse for a Negative team to stand up and be like 'Topicality' because there are arguments to be had there**. And students would learn and grow if the community could agree on a critical/cultural theory [Resolution]" Proceedings of the Tokyo Conference on Argumentation, Volume 6 - 140 - While Director Repko and I agreed on many issues and solutions for problems facing the debate community, the conditional embrace of the benefits of the KFM was not one of them. One of the very reasons Kritikal Affirmatives are valuable is because they speak truth to power to resist those inequitable arrangements. The voting blocs among powerful traditional schools, which run along the racial lines of the Clash of Civilizations, means that the controversies that appeal to KFM teams will not be chosen. This imbalance in institutional power is what inspired the broad readings of the topic by teams like Louisville, Towson, and Emporia. Much like number runners, the informal consensus among KFM teams about what controversies matter is a means for those without power to claim it by "hacking" the game. The fact that championship winning Kritik teams and coaches are able to identify, predict, and prepare for all of the "unpredictable" and "undebatable" Kritikal Affirmatives means that there is some stable point of departure. Rather than understanding the Resolution in a vacuum, **Kritik teams boldly acknowledge that the Resolution is contextualized by recent ground-breaking rounds, the larger history of debate, and academic debates** taking place when "The" controversy is considered ripe. The confluence of these factors, and the value that teams find in these debates, is what allows KFM teams to attune themselves to what I think of as a Radical Stasis Point and the mechanics of this model. Director Repko also finds that

engaging the Kritik does require more from coaches and students. We talked briefly about his team's shift in preparation after Georgetown AM won the 2012 NDT on the Complexity Kritik. He notes that, "... [A] lot of my time I spent pouring my familiarity into the heads of our students. There's a learning curve..." As someone who has been consistently been direct about his hesitance to fully embrace the KFM, I do take his concerns about time and competition shaping incentives seriously. There are some Affirmatives where one of the "gears", as he calls it, is to not defend a, "perspective from the literature but to defend an opinion of the affirmative". There is a risk that some Affirmative teams would escape to the margins of the topic to avoid a debate. These teams, however, are engaging the Negative in bad faith and would not be utilizing the KFM since they are not defending a Resolution-based change to the status quo that resolves a significant harm. The KFM does not attempt to duplicate the same level of policy precision that advocates of the PFM claim to. However, KFM does not dismiss the need for policy details to be germane to the Method of the Affirmative. I spoke to Robel Worku, a labor organizer in Denver, Colorado, about the role that details play in social justice. As a former qualifier to the Tournament of Champions and the NDT, he spent his time in debate engaging the PFM. He shared with me that "... policy details are important" specifically when speaking with legislators. Moreover, dismissing details," in the project of organizing and building power "lets people with power set the terms of discussion which," leaves power at the table." However, Robel does remember debating and watching Kritik teams such as West Georgia DF that would always articulate their arguments (Afroessimism, Critical Race Theory, Red Pedagogy) in the context of policy. Understanding the role that mechanisms play in ensuring enforcement or amending agreements is important and can be a valuable part of Kritik debates. However, he does not think that the focus on semantics in Topicality/Framework (TFW) debates is helpful in increasing understanding of those details. Srinidhi Mupalla, a software engineer, wanted debaters to temper their instinct to argue that maximizing details via an exclusive use of PFM is in anyone's best interest. In high school Srinidhi qualified to the TOC as a PFM debater in the D.C. area and went on to create one of the most successful flex teams as one half of Berkeley MS *3. He compared the details that you learn in Policy Debate to those works of literature: "I read that when you read a book or a novel, generally, over time you don't really remember the details, but you remember the shift in perspective or thinking. ...[E]ventually you'll forget all the little factoids learned and all you'll have is the singular perspective that you got from that. But if you do different kinds of debate you learn all the different perspectives... I don't really remember the details of [Ballistic Missile Defense] anymore... That stuff is useful, but you'll get that anyway. You don't need 8 or 9 years of that..." As our conversation continued, Srinidhi explained that there are diminishing returns when exclusively engaging in PFM. Unless a team was Proceedings of the Tokyo Conference on Argumentation, Volume 6 - 141 - "exploring across the academy" he did not feel like they would be able to produce nearly a decade of "meaningful education". His college debate partner Violet Spurlock, a former TOC champion and non-profit researcher, referred to their Marijuana Affirmative on the Legalization topic in 2014 that focused on building rhetorical strategies to, "... shift the [legalization] movement towards decarceration and anti-racist ends ...". She argued that it allowed them to learn about legalization policy from the perspective of activists, policymakers, and special interest groups while understanding how discourse around policy shapes implementation.

5. BEING NEGATIVE This paper has already established that there are often debatable controversies in the literature that give the Negative ground. By re-thinking what it means to evaluate the Resolution from a Radical Stasis Point and by reading across the academy, Negative teams can win within the KFM. There are countless Kritikal First-Round teams that prove that this is possible. TFW should be an option of last resort under the KFM (unless you are debating an undisclosed Affirmative) because it is overwhelmingly used to disengage from the content of the Affirmative (Odekirk & ReidBrinkley, 2012). There are three types of Kritik arguments that always engage the Affirmative— Case Turns, Counter-Methods, and Ethics Argument. Each of these operate similarly to PFM Disadvantages, Counterplans, and Structural Kritiks, respectively. Where teams generally falter is thinking through link the arguments that indict the Affirmative Method. Violet explained, as an incredibly flexible and successful 2N, that you need to first broaden your idea of what a link argument is. At first, she struggled with identifying places to clash with Kritik Affirmatives but realized that there are different "levels" of links that you can think through. Violet suggests that teams, "Think about the rhetoric of [the 1AC]. What kinds of language, metaphors, constructions of identity, value, and community are being invoked in this argument? How can we talk about the way that those rhetorical constructions shape the actual performance of the advocacy?" Moreover, Violet believes the easiest way to beat a Kritikal Affirmative is to respond to the 2AR, not the 1AC. By scouting other teams, historicizing the concepts and terms they use, and finding academic support for your links arguments she says you can find a specific strategy for every Affirmative. Alternatively, there is nothing wrong with a generic strategy in either a PFM or KFM. PFM teams generally argue that the Negative ground in Kritik debates is bland and unappealing. This claim would be more persuasive if there were not as many versions of the Antiblackness Kritik to learn, outside of any other argument, as there were viable Politics scenarios during the 2019- 2020 debate season. The challenge of the Kritik is finding literature that interests you and establishing conversations between that scholarship and the other team's. Dr. Sean Kennedy of Kansas KQ, one of most winningest and flexible teams of the decade, shared some of his thoughts about approaching the role of the Negative. As someone who coached multiple First-Rounds, Copeland Panelists, and top speakers under both the PFM and KFM his thoughts here are uniquely valuable for thinking through debate pedagogy. The first time he remembered debating a Kritikal Affirmative that was completely outside of his sphere of training, he was Negative against the 3- Tier Process Method *4. Before the round his coach, a Kansas debater, told him to try his best to engage, to be open-minded, and to move on the fly. When the Affirmative asked him to use certain types of evidence or styles of argument he did. From that one debate he learned a lesson about being Negative. He said from then on, "...[m]y thing was always just if the other team is doing this thing that is a little different from whatever the norm is just try and roll with it". In the early 2000's this approach was rare; most coaches and judges were trying to suppress the spread of the Kritik. Moreover, Dr. Kennedy could not recall a time when a coach or lab leader at summer workshop told him that he could not engage Kritikal Affirmatives. By the time he was in college he thought of himself as just a debater, not wed to either side of the culture wars, engaging other people on the merits of their arguments. As a coach he taught his Kritikal students to manage the workload of Kritik debate by breaking possible affirmative cases up into "genres", preparing for those areas broadly, and continuing to get more specific as you progress. Debating "genres" of arguments under the KFM is hard because it is uncomfortable to rethink cultural assumptions. Srinidhi, with distance from his years as a competitor, realized that, Proceedings of the Tokyo Conference on Argumentation, Volume 6 - 142 - **"Kritik debate requires one more element of critical thinking. You have to think about the thing you're reading, yourself in relation to it, and yourself in relation to the other people that you're debating ...It asks more in evaluating something previously unknown ..."** However, this is a feature of KFM, not a bug. To achieve the goal of epistemological growth, students must struggle with tough ethical and theoretical questions.

6. TOPICALITY AND FRAMEWORK A major objection to the Kritik-Focus Model of debate is that Topicality and Framework arguments that mandate the focus on the debate be the PFM are considered an option of last resort. The status quo of debate for the last twenty years for many teams has been to use TFW as a first option, regardless of the content or value of the Affirmative Method they faced in a debate. The reliance on TFW is ideological and relies on the enthymemes of "clash" and "preparation" that reflect the echo chamber of the traditionalists. Alternatively, many judges have increased burdens for Kritikal explanations of an inclusive model of debate. When given a "right" to TFW as a first option, the pedagogical benefits of the KFM can be skirted since **traditionalists will return to their comfort zone**. Unlike the university, students in debate should not have the ability to self-select out of conversations that center race, gender, class, or other critical points of departure*6. While we should not

preclude TFW in all instances, **we should hesitate to think that debating in the echo chamber of tradition is inherently valuable or fair.** It is inherently **unfair to students to allow them to go an entire season or debate career without gaining the education, critical thinking skills, or experiencing the epistemological growth provided by the KFM because of their fear of the unknown.** Tying the KFM to the incentive structure of debate while substantially increasing the burden on students who would read TFW as a first option is necessary to avoid self-selection. We can take the 2020 Copeland Panel as a case study of argument avoidance. The Copeland winning team Berkeley FG had approximately 40 Negative debates and were slotted to negate against Kritik Methods 10 times. In each instance they used TFW to self-select out of critical conversations.

The role of the ballot is to vote for the debater who most effectively protects marginalized communities. To clarify, they can keep their offense but they must prove how they weigh under our ROTB.

Prefer it:

- 1. INCLUSION.** Topical debates punish debaters for reading feminist arguments. Affirmation of our role of the ballot means affirmation of women-focused arguments which allows for a greater scope to be allowed into this space which is critical for expansion of women's rights.
- 2. PRE-REQs.** Gender inequality is a paramount issue and solving for it now is a moral obligation upon the judge. Any other issues come second - without solving for women subjugation we ensure they continue to fail. The K is the only way to solve for women's rights.

Underview

- 1. K uplayers.** Our evidence proves that solving for gender equality and women's right is most important.
- 2. They must answer our role of the ballot in the next speech or concede it. Two warrants:**
 - a. FRAMING.** Without a set role of the ballot by the time of 1st rebuttal 8 minutes of offense are wasted on both sides - that makes the round unfair to debate.
 - b. PREP-SKEW.** If they don't answer immediately then that means they get 7 minutes of prep while we only have 4 minutes to respond - that structurally skews us out of the round.

constructive end

AT: Capitalism

First let's define materialism - we tell you it is the chase of desire. That's our first card. Thus we actually gave rise to cap because this chase is why we see the capitalist structures we do now.

We r prereq for cap because materialism came BEFORE capitalism, and when we encourage the buddhist ideology.

Dematerialization makes growth sustainable.

Andrew McAfee, 10/15/2019, More from Less: The Surprising Story of How We Learned to Prosper Using Fewer Resources—and What Happens,
[//">https://www.everand.com/book/425632102/More-from-Less-The-Surprising-Story-of-How-We-Learned-to-Prosper-Using-Fewer-Resources-and-What-Happens-Next\)//](https://www.everand.com/book/425632102/More-from-Less-The-Surprising-Story-of-How-We-Learned-to-Prosper-Using-Fewer-Resources-and-What-Happens-Next) recut JZ

There is no shortage of examples of **dematerialization**. I chose the ones in this chapter because they **illustrate** a set of **fundamental principles at the intersection of business, economics, innovation, and our impact on our planet**. They are: **We do want more all the time, but not more resources**. Alfred Marshall was right, but William Jevons was wrong. **Our wants and desires keep growing, evidently without end, and therefore so do our economies. But our use of the earth's resources does not. We do want more beverage options, but we don't want to keep using more aluminum in drink cans. We want to communicate and compute and listen to music, but we don't want an arsenal of gadgets; we're happy with a single smartphone. As our population increases, we want more food, but we don't have any desire to consume more fertilizer or use more land for crops. Jevons was correct at the time** he that total British demand for coal was increasing even though steam engines were becoming much more efficient. He was right, in other words, that the price elasticity of demand for coal-supplied power was greater than one in the 1860s. **But he was wrong to conclude that this would be permanent. Elasticities of demand can change over time** for several reasons, the most fundamental of which is technological change. **Coal provides a clear example of this. When fracking made natural gas much cheaper, total demand for coal in the United States went down even though its price decreased.** **With the help of innovation and new technologies, economic growth** in America and other rich countries— growth in all of the wants and needs that we spend money on— **has become decoupled from resource consumption**. This is a recent development and a profound one. **Materials cost money** that **companies** locked in competition **would rather not spend**. The root of Jevons's mistake is simple and boring: **resources cost money**. He realized this, of course. What **he didn't sufficiently realize** was **how strong the incentive** is for a company in a contested market **to reduce its spending on resources** (or anything else) and so eke out a bit more profit. After all, a penny saved is a penny earned. **Monopolists can just pass costs on to their customers, but companies with a lot of competitors can't. So American farmers who battle with each other** (and increasingly **with tough rivals in other countries**) **are**

eager to cut their spending on land, water, and fertilizer. Beer and soda companies want to minimize their aluminum purchases. Producers of magnets and high tech gear run away from REE as soon as prices start to spike. In the United States, the 1980 Staggers Act removed government subsidies for freight-hauling railroads, forcing them into competition and cost cutting and making them all the more eager to not have expensive railcars sit idle. **Again and again, we see that competition spurs dematerialization.** **There are multiple paths to dematerialization.** As **profit-hungry companies** seek to use fewer resources, they can go down four main paths. First, they can simply find ways to use less of a given material. This is what happened as beverage companies and the companies that supply them with cans teamed up to use less aluminum. It's also the story with American farmers, who keep getting bigger harvests while using less land, water, and fertilizer. Magnet makers found ways to use fewer rare earth metals when it looked as if China might cut off their supply. Second, it often becomes possible to substitute one resource for another. Total US coal consumption started to decrease after 2007 because fracking made natural gas more attractive to electricity generators. If nuclear power becomes more popular in the United States (a topic we'll take up in chapter 15), we could use both less coal and less gas and generate our electricity from a small amount of material indeed. A kilogram of uranium-235 fuel contains approximately 2–3 million times as much energy as the same mass of coal or oil. According to one estimate, the total amount of energy that humans consume each year could be supplied by just seven thousand tons of uranium fuel. Third, **companies can use fewer molecules overall by making better use of the materials they already own.** Improving CNW's railcar utilization from 5 percent to 10 percent would mean that the company could cut its stock of these thirty ton behemoths in half. **Companies that own expensive physical assets tend to be fanatics about getting as much use as possible out of them, for clear and compelling financial reasons.** For example, the world's commercial airlines have improved their load factors—essentially the percentage of seats occupied on flights—from 56 percent in 1971 to more than 81 percent in 2018. Finally, **some materials get replaced by nothing at all. When a telephone, camcorder, and tape recorder are separate devices, three total microphones are needed. When they all collapse into a smartphone, only one microphone is necessary.** That smartphone also uses no audiotapes, videotapes, compact discs, or camera film. **The iPhone and its descendants are among the world champions of dematerialization. They use vastly less metal, plastic, glass, and silicon than did the devices they have replaced and don't need media such as paper, discs, tape, or film. If we use more renewable energy, we'll be replacing coal, gas, oil, and uranium with photons from the sun (solar power) and the movement of air (wind power) and water (hydroelectric power)** on the earth. All three of these types of power are also among dematerialization's champions, since **they use up essentially no resources** once they're up and running. I call **these** four **paths to dematerialization** slim, swap, optimize, and evaporate. **They're not mutually exclusive. Companies can and do pursue all four at the same time, and all four are going on all the time** in ways both obvious and subtle. **Innovation is hard to foresee. Neither the fracking revolution nor the world-changing impact of the iPhone's introduction were well understood in advance. Both continued to be underestimated even after they occurred.** The iPhone was introduced in June of 2007, with no shortage of fanfare from Apple and Steve Jobs. Yet several months later the cover of Forbes was still asking if anyone could catch Nokia. **Innovation is not steady and predictable** like the orbit of the Moon or the accumulation of interest on a certificate of deposit. **It's** instead **inherently jumpy, uneven, and random. It's also combinatorial**, as Erik Brynjolfsson and I discussed in our book *The Second Machine Age*. **Most new technologies and other innovations, we argued, are combinations or recombinations of preexisting elements.** The iPhone was "just" a cellular telephone plus a bunch of sensors plus a touch screen plus an operating system and population of programs, or apps. All these elements had been around for a while before 2007. It took the vision of Steve Jobs to see what they could become when combined. Fracking was the combination of multiple abilities: to "see" where hydrocarbons were to be found in rock formations deep underground; to pump down pressurized liquid to fracture the rock; to pump up the oil and gas once they were released by the fracturing; and so on. Again, none of these was new. Their effective combination was what changed the world's energy situation. Erik and I described **the set of innovations and technologies available at any time as building blocks that ingenious people could combine and recombine into useful new configurations. These new configurations then serve as more blocks that later innovators can use. Combinatorial innovation is exciting because it's unpredictable. It's not easy to foresee when or where powerful new combinations are going to appear,**

or who's going to come up with them. But as the number of both building blocks and innovators increases, we should have confidence that more breakthroughs such as fracking and smartphones are ahead. Innovation is highly decentralized and largely uncoordinated, occurring as the result of interactions among complex and interlocking social, technological, and economic systems. **So it's going to keep surprising us. As the Second Machine Age progresses, dematerialization accelerates.** Erik and I coined the phrase Second Machine Age to draw a contrast with the Industrial Era, which as we've seen transformed the planet by allowing us to overcome the limitations of muscle power. **Our current time of great progress with all things related to computing is allowing us to overcome the limitations of our mental power and is** transformative in a different way: it's **allowing us to reverse the Industrial Era's bad habit of taking more and more from the earth every year.** Computer-aided design tools help engineers at packaging companies design generations of aluminum cans that keep getting lighter. Fracking took off in part because oil and gas exploration companies learned how to build accurate computer models of the rock formations that lay deep underground—models that predicted where hydrocarbons were to be found. Smartphones took the place of many separate pieces of gear. Because they serve as GPS devices, they've also led us to print out many fewer maps and so contributed to our current trend of using less paper. It's easy to look at generations of computer paper, from 1960s punch cards to the eleven-by-seventeen-inch fanfold paper of the 1980s, and conclude that the Second Machine Age has caused us to chop down ever more trees. The year of peak paper consumption in the United States, however, was 1990. As our devices have become more capable and interconnected, always on and always with us, we've sharply turned away from paper. Humanity as a whole probably hit peak paper in 2013. As these examples indicate, **computers and their kin help us with** all four paths to **dematerialization. Hardware, software, and networks let us slim, swap, optimize, and evaporate.** I contend that **they're the best tools we've ever invented for letting us tread more lightly on the planet.** All of **these principles are about the combination of technological progress and capitalism,** which are the first of the two pairs of forces causing dematerialization.